Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 22 · DAYS 785-819

In Christ: Prison and Pastoral Epistles

Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Thessalonians, Pastoral Epistles, Philemon

The church as the new humanity. Joy, hope, Christ's supremacy, and sound doctrine.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation."

COLOSSIANS 1:15-16

The ascended Christ (68, 110) and trust under pressure (27, 138, 139).

UNIT 22

In this unit

WEEK 113

785	Ephesians 1:1-23	*Reading*
786	Ephesians 1:3-14; Romans 9:1-24	*Doctrine*
787	Matthew 16:13-20; Ephesians 2:11-22; 1 Peter 2:4-10	*Doctrine*
788	Ephesians 2:1-3:21	*Reading*
789	Ephesians 4:1-32	*Reading*
790	Ephesians 5:1-6:24	*Reading*
791	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 114

792	Psalm 68:1-20	*Psalm*
793	Psalm 110:1-7	*Psalm*
794	Philippians 1:1-2:30	*Reading*
795	Philippians 2:5-11; Hebrews 2:14-18	*Doctrine*
796	Philippians 3:1-4:23	*Reading*
797	Colossians 1:1-2:5	*Reading*
798	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 115

799	Colossians 2:6-3:17	*Reading*
800	Colossians 3:18-4:18	*Reading*
801	1 Corinthians 7:17-24; Colossians 3:22-4:1	*Doctrine*
802	1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13	*Reading*
803	1 Thessalonians 4:13-18; Matthew 24:30-31; Revelation 1:7	*Doctrine*
804	1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28	*Reading*
805	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 116

806	Psalm 27	*Psalm*

807	Psalm 138	*Psalm*
808	Psalm 139:13-24	*Psalm*
809	2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18	*Reading*
810	1 Timothy 1:1-3:16	*Reading*
811	1 Timothy 3:1-13; Titus 1:5-9; Acts 6:1-6	*Doctrine*
812	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 117

813	1 Timothy 4:1-6:21	*Reading*
814	2 Timothy 1:1-2:26	*Reading*
815	2 Timothy 3:1-4:22	*Reading*
816	Titus 1:1-3:15	*Reading*
817	Philemon 1:1-25	*Reading*
818	Review and Reflection	*Review*
819	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 785 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 1:1-23

Every spiritual blessing in Christ

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 1:1-23. The first fourteen verses are one long sentence in Greek, a single burst of praise. Read it aloud if you can, and notice how many times Paul says “in Christ” or “in him.” Then read the prayer in verses 15-23.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul wrote Ephesians from prison in Rome, around AD 60 to 62, probably as a circular letter for the churches around Ephesus. Together with Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon, it is one of the Prison Epistles. Ephesians has no urgent problem to correct. It is a sustained celebration of what God has done in Christ and what the church is. The first three chapters tell what God has done; the last three tell how to live in light of it.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places” (1:3).
2. “Even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him” (1:4).
3. “He predestined us for adoption as sons through Jesus Christ” (1:5).
4. “In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace” (1:7).
5. “A plan for the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth” (1:10).

6. “In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit” (1:13).

7. “Having the eyes of your hearts enlightened, that you may know what is the hope to which he has called you” (1:18).

8. “He put all things under his feet and gave him as head over all things to the church, which is his body” (1:22-23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening is a hymn of praise, not an argument. Paul blesses God because God has blessed us “with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places.” Every blessing is “in Christ.” The rest of the sentence unfolds the blessings in Trinitarian order. The Father chose us “before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless,” and predestined us for adoption “to the praise of his glorious grace.” The Son redeemed us: “In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses.” The Spirit sealed us: when we believed, we “were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit, who is the guarantee of our inheritance until we acquire possession of it.” Three times the refrain returns: to the praise of his glory.

Notice the scope. God’s plan reaches back before creation and forward to “the fullness of time, to unite all things in him, things in heaven and things on earth.” The mystery of his will is that all of history is heading toward one goal: the summing up of everything under Christ. Believers are given an inheritance, obtained “in him,” having been predestined according to the purpose of the God who works all things according to the counsel of his will. We were not an afterthought. We are part of a plan.

Paul then prays for the readers. He gives thanks for their faith and love, and asks that God give them “the Spirit of wisdom and of revelation in the knowledge of him,” so that the eyes of their hearts may be enlightened. He prays for three things: that they know the hope of his calling, the riches of the glory of his inheritance in the saints, and the immeasurable greatness of his power toward us who believe. The measure of that power is the resurrection and exaltation of Christ: God raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule and authority and power and dominion, and above every name that is named. “And he put all things under his feet and gave him as head over all things to the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all.”

The church is not an afterthought either. Christ rules the universe for the sake of the church. The same power that raised Jesus is at work in believers. When we feel weak, we are to remember that this is the power on our side.

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 8:28-39 and 2 Timothy 1:9 speak of God's purpose before the ages. Colossians 1:15-20 and Philippians 2:9-11 speak of Christ's supremacy. 1 Peter 1:3-5 praises God for a living hope and an inheritance. Psalm 110:1 and Psalm 8:6 stand behind 1:20-22. John 17:24 speaks of the Father's love before the foundation of the world. 2 Corinthians 1:21-22 speaks of the seal and guarantee. Revelation 5:9-14 shows the Lamb worshiped. Romans 11:33-36 is a similar doxology.

STEP 6

Application

Read verses 3 to 14 aloud as a prayer, slowly. Underline each blessing.

Pray for yourself the prayer of verses 17 to 19: that the eyes of your heart would be enlightened.

When you feel weak, remember that the power that raised Christ is at work in you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bless God for blessing you in Christ with every spiritual blessing.
- Thank him for choosing you, adopting you, and sealing you.
- Ask him to open the eyes of your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 786 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 1:3-14; Romans 9:1-24

Election and Predestination

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 1:3-14 and Romans 9:1-24. Today is a doctrinal pause on election and predestination. Read slowly and with humility. Notice the repeated phrase “in him” in Ephesians and the emphasis on God’s mercy in Romans.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Few doctrines have been as debated as election, and few are as comforting when understood. The word means choosing. Ephesians 1 speaks of God choosing us in Christ before the foundation of the world. Romans 9 stresses that God’s purpose of election works by his mercy, not by human merit or descent. The doctrine is not meant to start arguments but to produce worship, humility, and security. Notice that Ephesians 1 is written in a hymn of praise.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him” (Ephesians 1:4).
2. “He predestined us for adoption as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will” (Ephesians 1:5).
3. “To the praise of his glorious grace, with which he has blessed us in the Beloved” (Ephesians 1:6).
4. “In him we have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works all things according to the counsel of his will” (Ephesians 1:11).

5. “In order that God’s purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls” (Romans 9:11).
6. “For he says to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I have compassion” (Romans 9:15).
7. “So then it depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy” (Romans 9:16).
8. “In order to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, which he has prepared beforehand for glory” (Romans 9:23).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

Election is God’s choice, before creation and from his own mercy, of a people to be saved in Christ. Predestination is closely related and speaks of God determining beforehand the destiny of those he has chosen: adoption, holiness, and glory. The Bible uses these words, so Christians must take them seriously. They are not ideas of a particular school but of Scripture.

The central point is clear in every tradition: salvation is God’s gift, not human achievement. The Father chose us “in him,” in Christ. We are not chosen because of foreseen goodness. We were chosen “that we should be holy and blameless,” not because we were. The purpose is the praise of his glorious grace. The result is humility and security: God began the work, and he will finish it (Philippians 1:6; Romans 8:29-30).

Christians have understood the details differently. In the Reformed (Calvinist) tradition, God unconditionally chose particular individuals for salvation before the foundation of the world, and he effectually calls them so that they certainly believe. In the Arminian tradition, God elects on the basis of his foreknowledge of who would respond in faith, or elects the church as a corporate body in Christ and individuals as they join it by faith. Other views stress corporate election: Christ is the Chosen One, and those who are in him share his election. Roman Catholic and Orthodox traditions have their own formulations. These debates have been serious and will not be settled here.

Some guidelines help us read faithfully. Hold the mystery: God is sovereign, and human beings are genuinely responsible. Scripture teaches both, and we are not asked to fully reconcile them. Remember the purpose: Paul teaches election to comfort and to elicit praise, not to discourage evangelism. The same Paul who wrote Romans 9 wrote Romans 10 about the necessity of preaching. And never use election as an excuse for pride or fatalism. The right response is worship.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Ephesians 1, election is first of all about Christ. We were chosen "in him." Jesus is the chosen one, and we share in his election by union with him. The purpose of election is holiness and adoption. It is not a doctrine of exclusion but of grace: "In love he predestined us for adoption." Everything is done "according to the purpose of his will," "to the praise of his glorious grace."

Romans 9 focuses on the question of Israel: why have so many of God's people not believed? Paul's answer begins with a reminder: "Not all who are descended from Israel belong to Israel." The promise always went through God's choice: Isaac, not Ishmael; Jacob, not Esau. "Though they were not yet born and had done nothing either good or bad, in order that God's purpose of election might continue, not because of works but because of him who calls." Paul anticipates the objection: is God unjust? "By no means! For he says to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I have mercy." Salvation "depends not on human will or exertion, but on God, who has mercy." No one deserves mercy; if God gives it to some, no one is wronged. The potter has the right over the clay. And Paul adds that God endures with much patience vessels of wrath prepared for destruction, in order to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy, "whom he has prepared beforehand for glory, even us whom he has called, not from the Jews only but also from the Gentiles."

If you are a Christian, the doctrine means that your salvation does not ultimately rest on your grip on God but on his grip on you. If you are not sure whether you are chosen, the answer is found in the gospel call: come to Christ. "Whoever believes in him will not be put to shame." No one who comes to him is cast out (John 6:37).

STEP 5

Connection

John 6:37-44 and 15:16 speak of the Father giving and drawing. Acts 13:48 says as many as were appointed to eternal life believed. Romans 8:28-30 gives the golden chain. 2 Thessalonians 2:13 speaks of being chosen as firstfruits. 1 Peter 1:1-2 and 2 Peter 1:10 speak of election. Deuteronomy 7:6-8 gives God's choice of Israel from love. 2 Peter 3:9 and 1 Timothy 2:4 speak of God's desire that all be saved. Revelation 13:8 and 17:8 mention the book of life. Philippians 2:12-13 pairs God's work and ours.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God for choosing you, if you are in Christ. Let it humble you and make you secure.

Pray for someone who does not believe. The doctrine of election should drive us to pray and to share the gospel, not away from it.

When you disagree with another Christian on this doctrine, respond with love, remembering that both of you are seeking to honor God's word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for choosing you in Christ before the foundation of the world.
- Tell him what you cannot fully understand, and rest in him.
- Ask him to make you humble and holy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 787 · WEEK 113

Matthew 16:13-20; Ephesians 2:11-22; 1 Peter 2:4-10

The Nature of the Church

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Matthew 16:13-20, Ephesians 2:11-22, and 1 Peter 2:4-10. Today is a doctrinal pause on the nature of the church. Notice the images used: a rock, a household, a temple, a priesthood, and a people.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The word “church” translates the Greek ekklesia, which means an assembly or gathering. In the Old Testament, it was used for the assembly of Israel. Jesus used the word only twice in the Gospels (Matthew 16:18 and 18:17), but in the rest of the New Testament it appears over a hundred times. The church is central to God’s plan. It is not a human invention but the people whom God has gathered to himself through Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God” (Matthew 16:16).
2. “On this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matthew 16:18).
3. “But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ” (Ephesians 2:13).
4. “For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one” (Ephesians 2:14).
5. “You are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God” (Ephesians 2:19).
6. “Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone” (Ephesians 2:20).

7. “You yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house, to be a holy priesthood” (1 Peter 2:5).

8. “But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession” (1 Peter 2:9).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The church is the people of God, called out of the world by the gospel and united to Christ by the Spirit. It is described in many ways: the body of Christ, the bride of Christ, the household and family of God, the temple of the Spirit, the flock of the Good Shepherd, the pillar and buttress of truth, and the people of God. Each image teaches something. The body speaks of union and mutual dependence; the bride, of love and purity; the family, of belonging; the temple, of God’s presence; the flock, of care.

We can distinguish the universal church and the local church. The universal church is all those united to Christ by faith in every time and place. The local church is a particular gathering of believers who meet regularly under the word, practice the ordinances, and are accountable to each other. Many theologians distinguish the visible church, which includes everyone who professes faith, from the invisible church, which includes only those who are truly regenerate. The marks of a true church, according to the Reformers, are the faithful preaching of the word and the right administration of the sacraments or ordinances. Many add discipline.

The church is what Israel was called to be, now expanded to include Gentiles. In Ephesians 2, Paul says that Gentiles who were “alienated from the commonwealth of Israel” are now fellow citizens. In 1 Peter 2:9, the titles once given to Israel in Exodus 19:5-6 are given to the church: a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation. This is part of the progressive covenantal reading of Scripture: Christ is the true Israel, and the church, united to him, is the people of God, in continuity with the Old Testament people and yet new.

Christians differ on the meaning of “on this rock” in Matthew 16:18. Roman Catholics hold that the rock is Peter, as the first pope. Many Protestants hold that the rock is Peter’s confession (that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the living God), or Christ himself, or Peter as representative of the apostles. Christians also differ on church government, which we study on Day 811. All agree that Christ builds his church and that it will not fail.

STEP 4

Interpretation

At Caesarea Philippi, Jesus asks, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter answers, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” Jesus blesses him: flesh and blood did not reveal this, but the Father. “And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.” The church is built on the apostolic confession of who Jesus is. Whether the “rock” is Peter, his confession, or both, the point is clear: Christ is the builder, and the gates of death will not stop him. Jesus also gives the keys of the kingdom, the authority to declare, through the gospel, who enters.

Ephesians 2:11-22 describes the church as a new humanity. Gentiles were “separated from Christ, alienated from the commonwealth of Israel and strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in the world.” But now they have been brought near. Christ “has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility” between Jew and Gentile, by abolishing the law of commandments expressed in ordinances, “that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two.” Together they have access in one Spirit to the Father. “So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, built on the foundation of the apostles and the prophets, Christ Jesus himself being the cornerstone, in whom the whole structure, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord.” The church is a building with Christ at its center and a living organism that is growing.

Peter adds that believers are “living stones” built into a spiritual house, a holy priesthood to offer spiritual sacrifices. Christ is the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious. For those who believe, he is precious; for those who do not, he is a stone of stumbling. Believers have a purpose: “that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light.” “Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.”

The church is the community of the redeemed. It is not optional for the Christian. We were saved into a people.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 19:5-6 is the source of 1 Peter 2:9. Psalm 118:22 and Isaiah 28:16 are quoted in 1 Peter 2:6-8. Hosea 1:9 to 2:23 is echoed in 1 Peter 2:10. Matthew 18:15-20 gives Jesus’ words on the church. Acts 2:42-47 shows the first church. 1 Corinthians 12:12-27 describes the body. Hebrews 10:24-25 urges us not to neglect meeting together. Revelation 21:9-14 pictures the bride and the city. Ephesians 5:25-27 says Christ loved the church and gave himself for her.

STEP 6

Application

If you are not part of a local church, prayerfully find one this week. If you are, thank God for it.

Ask what it would mean to see your fellow members as brothers and sisters, not as an audience.

Think of the church's mission: to proclaim the excellencies of him who called us.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for building his church.
- Ask him to show you your place in it.
- Pray for your own church.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 788 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 2:1-3:21

By grace through faith; the new humanity; the mystery

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 2:1-3:21. Chapter 2 is the gospel in miniature: dead, made alive, saved by grace, made one. Chapter 3 is about the mystery of the Gentiles' inclusion and ends with a prayer and a doxology. Take time with 2:8-10 and 3:14-21.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In chapter 1, Paul described what God has done in eternity and in Christ. In chapter 2, he describes what happened to us: we were dead, and God made us alive. Then he describes what happened between Jew and Gentile: the wall came down. Chapter 3 explains that this was the long-hidden mystery, and Paul's calling is to proclaim it. The chapter closes with one of Paul's greatest prayers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And you were dead in the trespasses and sins" (2:1).
2. "But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ" (2:4-5).
3. "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast" (2:8-9).
4. "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them" (2:10).
5. "That he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace" (2:15).

6. “This mystery is that the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel” (3:6).

7. “That you, being rooted and grounded in love, may have strength to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth” (3:17-18).

8. “Now to him who is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power at work within us, to him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus throughout all generations, forever and ever” (3:20-21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter begins with the worst news: “You were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air.” Dead is dead. Not sick, not weak, but dead. We were by nature children of wrath, carrying out the desires of the body and the mind. This is a bleak but accurate picture of humanity without Christ.

Then the two most beautiful words in the Bible: “But God.” “But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ.” The sequence is raising with Christ, seating with Christ. All of it is grace. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.” Faith itself is a gift. Salvation excludes boasting. Yet it is not for idleness: “For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.” We are not saved by works, but we are saved for works. The word “workmanship” is poiema, from which we get “poem.” We are God’s work of art.

Verses 11 to 22 turn to the Gentiles, who were far off. “But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. For he himself is our peace.” The “dividing wall of hostility” may allude to the barrier in the temple that kept Gentiles out of the inner courts. Christ abolished the hostility and made one new humanity. This is a key text for understanding the relationship between Israel and the church: not replacement, but a new creation in which Jew and Gentile are united in one body under one Head.

In chapter 3, Paul speaks of the mystery: “that the Gentiles are fellow heirs, members of the same body, and partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus through the gospel.” It was not made known in other generations as it has now been revealed. Paul has been given the grace to preach to the Gentiles “the unsearchable riches of Christ” and to make known to the rulers and authorities in the heavenly places the manifold wisdom of God through the church. Even angels learn about God by watching the church.

He bows his knees and prays: that God would strengthen them with power through his Spirit in the inner being, that Christ may dwell in their hearts through faith, that they being rooted and grounded in love may comprehend the breadth and length and height and depth, and know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge, "that you may be filled with all the fullness of God." It is a prayer for knowing what cannot be fully known. And then the doxology, to the God who can do more than we ask or think.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 3 and Romans 5:12-21 explain our deadness in Adam. Romans 3:21-28 and Titus 3:3-7 teach salvation by grace. Isaiah 57:19 is cited in 2:17. Colossians 1:26-27 also speaks of the mystery. Romans 16:25-27 is a related doxology. Galatians 3:26-29 speaks of union of Jew and Gentile. John 15:5 and Colossians 3:3-4 speak of Christ in us. 1 Peter 1:10-12 says angels long to look into these things. Jude 24-25 is another doxology.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Ephesians 2:8-10. Write it where you will see it.

Ask what "good works" God has prepared for you today, and look for one.

Pray Paul's prayer of 3:16-19 for a friend or for your church.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for making you alive when you were dead in sin.
- Thank him that you are saved by grace through faith, a gift.
- Ask him to help you walk in the good works he prepared.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 789 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 4:1-32

Unity; spiritual gifts; the new self

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 4:1-32. The letter turns from “what God has done” to “how we then should live.” Read the first sixteen verses on unity and gifts, and the last verses on putting off the old self and putting on the new.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Chapters 1 to 3 are doctrine; chapters 4 to 6 are practice. The word “therefore” at the start of chapter 4 connects them. The Christian life is a response to what God has done. Paul begins with the church’s unity, then moves to individuals: how to live as a new person. This chapter links with Psalm 68 and Psalm 110, which we read in the coming days.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “I therefore, a prisoner for the Lord, urge you to walk in a manner worthy of the calling to which you have been called” (4:1).
2. “Eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace” (4:3).
3. “One Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all” (4:5-6).
4. “Rather, speaking the truth in love, we are to grow up in every way into him who is the head, into Christ” (4:15).
5. “To put on the new self, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness” (4:24).
6. “Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, but only such as is good for building up” (4:29).

7. “And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption” (4:30).

8. “Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you” (4:32).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul, “a prisoner for the Lord,” urges the church to walk worthy of their calling: “with all humility and gentleness, with patience, bearing with one another in love, eager to maintain the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.” Notice that unity is something we maintain, not create. The Spirit has already made us one. The basis is the seven “ones”: one body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all. The Trinity is the foundation of church unity.

Unity is not uniformity. “But grace was given to each one of us according to the measure of Christ’s gift.” Paul quotes Psalm 68:18: “When he ascended on high he led a host of captives, and he gave gifts to men.” The ascended Christ gives gifts to his church: apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds, and teachers, “to equip the saints for the work of ministry, for building up the body of Christ, until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ.” The goal is Christlikeness, and the means is the ministry of every member. Immaturity is marked by being “tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine.” Maturity is marked by “speaking the truth in love” and growing into Christ.

Verses 17 to 24 describe the change. The Gentiles walk “in the futility of their minds,” darkened in understanding, hardened in heart, callous, given over to sensuality. “But that is not the way you learned Christ.” The imagery is clothing: put off the old self, which is corrupt through deceitful desires, be renewed in the spirit of your minds, and put on the new self, “created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.” Holiness starts with a change of identity and shows up in daily choices.

Then practical commands, each with a reason. Put away falsehood and speak the truth, for we are members one of another. Be angry and do not sin; do not let the sun go down on your anger. Let the thief no longer steal, but work, so that he may have something to share with the needy. Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, only what is good for building up. “And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.” The Spirit is a person who can be grieved by sin, especially by bitterness and malice. Instead: “Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you.” The standard of forgiveness is the cross.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 68:18 is quoted in 4:8. Colossians 3:5-17 is a parallel on putting off and putting on. 1 Corinthians 12 and Romans 12 treat the gifts. John 17:20-23 is Jesus' prayer for unity. Zechariah 8:16 stands behind 4:25. Psalm 4:4 is quoted in 4:26. Matthew 6:14-15 and 18:21-35 teach forgiveness. Hebrews 12:15 warns against a root of bitterness. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of the new creation. 1 Thessalonians 5:19 says not to quench the Spirit.

STEP 6

Application

Identify one place where you could maintain unity: a strained relationship at church or home. Take a step.

Examine your words this week. Ask, is this good for building up?

Forgive someone as God in Christ forgave you, if you need to.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you walk worthy of your calling.

Ask him to make you humble, gentle, and patient.

Ask him to help you put off the old self and put on the new.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 790 · WEEK 113

Ephesians 5:1-6:24

Walk in love; household codes; the armor of God

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 5:1-6:24. This long reading continues the practical section: walking in love and light, being filled with the Spirit, relationships in the household, and the armor of God. Read with care, as Paul's teaching on marriage is both beautiful and debated. Read the armor of God as an invitation to stand.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul continues his instructions for the Christian life. He starts with imitating God and walking in love, then describes life in the Spirit, then addresses relationships in the household: wives and husbands, children and parents, slaves and masters. Finally he turns to spiritual warfare. The household instructions were countercultural. Husbands are told to love like Christ; children, wives, and slaves are addressed as moral agents; masters are warned that they have a Master in heaven.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God" (5:2).
2. "And do not get drunk with wine, for that is debauchery, but be filled with the Spirit" (5:18).
3. "Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ" (5:21).
4. "Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her" (5:25).
5. "Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might" (6:10).

6. “For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness” (6:12).
7. “And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God” (6:17).
8. “Praying at all times in the Spirit, with all prayer and supplication” (6:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

“Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children. And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us.” The pattern for the Christian life is God’s own love in Christ. Paul warns against sexual immorality, impurity, covetousness, and obscene talk, which are not fitting among saints. “For at one time you were darkness, but now you are light in the Lord. Walk as children of light.” Light exposes darkness and shows what pleases the Lord.

“Be filled with the Spirit.” This is a command in the present tense, meaning to keep being filled. It is contrasted with drunkenness: instead of being controlled by wine, be controlled by the Spirit. The results are described in participles: speaking to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody to the Lord, giving thanks, and submitting to one another. A Spirit-filled life is marked by worship, gratitude, and mutual submission.

Then the household. “Submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ” introduces the passage. “Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife even as Christ is the head of the church.” The key is the pattern of Christ. Husbands are told, “Love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her.” Headship is defined by sacrificial love. Marriage is a picture of Christ and the church: “This mystery is profound, and I am saying that it refers to Christ and the church.” Christians differ on the application: complementarians understand the passage to describe distinct roles in which husbands lead and wives submit, while egalitarians stress mutual submission in verse 21 and understand headship as source or servant leadership. Both agree that husbands must love sacrificially and that abuse of any kind violates this text.

Children are to obey their parents in the Lord, for it is right, and honor them, the first commandment with a promise. Fathers are not to provoke their children to anger, but to bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord. Slaves are to obey with sincerity, as serving Christ, and masters are to do the same to them, knowing that both have a Master in heaven who shows no partiality. Paul’s teaching undermines the slave system from within.

The letter ends with a call to battle. “Be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the schemes of the devil.” The enemy is not human but spiritual. The armor: the belt of truth, the breastplate of righteousness, shoes of the readiness given by the gospel of peace, the shield of faith, the helmet of salvation, the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God. Almost all of it is defensive; the aim is to stand. And all of it is surrounded by prayer: “praying at all times in the Spirit.” Paul asks for prayer for himself, that he would declare the gospel boldly. The letter ends with peace, love, and grace.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 2:24 is quoted in 5:31. Exodus 20:12 is quoted in 6:2-3. Isaiah 11:4-5, 52:7, and 59:17 stand behind the armor. 1 Peter 3:1-7 gives parallel household teaching. Colossians 3:18 to 4:1 is a close parallel. Philemon applies the teaching on masters and slaves. Psalm 119 praises the word. 2 Corinthians 10:3-5 describes spiritual warfare. 1 Peter 5:8-9 warns of the devil. Matthew 4:1-11 shows Jesus using the sword of the Spirit. James 4:7 says resist the devil.

STEP 6

Application

Pray through each piece of the armor this week. Name each as you put it on.

If you are married, ask your spouse how you could love them more like Christ. If you are a parent, look for an area where you can bring up your children in the Lord.

Pray for a missionary or pastor who is boldly declaring the gospel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you walk in love as Christ loved you.
- Ask him to fill you with his Spirit.
- Ask him to help you put on the whole armor of God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 113

“For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.”

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

DAY 791 · WEEK 113

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Ephesians 2:8-9 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast."

EPHESIANS 2:8-9

REST

Meditation

These two verses may be the most quoted summary of the gospel of grace.

"For by grace." Grace is God's favor given freely to those who do not deserve it. It is the source of everything.

"You have been saved." The verb is in the perfect tense: it was done in the past with results that continue. You are not hoping to be saved by your effort; you have been saved.

"Through faith." Faith is the means by which we receive what grace offers. It is not a work but an empty hand. It looks to Christ.

"And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God." Everything, including the faith itself, is God's gift. We did not contribute.

“Not a result of works, so that no one may boast.” If salvation depended on us even a little, we could take some credit. As it is, all the glory goes to God.

And verse 10 adds what follows: we are his workmanship, created for good works. We are saved by grace, not by works, but for works.

When pride or despair threatens, say these verses. Both are answered by grace.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the Prison Epistles with Ephesians. In chapter 1, Paul praised God for blessing us in Christ with every spiritual blessing: chosen, adopted, redeemed, and sealed with the Spirit, to the praise of his glorious grace. Two doctrinal pauses considered election and predestination, and the nature of the church as the people of God built on Christ the cornerstone. Ephesians 2 and 3 showed us dead in sin and made alive by grace through faith, Jew and Gentile made one new humanity, and the mystery of Christ revealed. Chapters 4 to 6 turned to life in Christ: unity of the Spirit, gifts for equipping the saints, putting off the old self and putting on the new, walking in love, the household, and the armor of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says every spiritual blessing is ours in Christ. Which of the blessings in Ephesians 1:3-14 is hardest for you to believe is true of you? How might you remind yourself of it this week?

Ephesians 2:8-10 says we are saved by grace through faith, for good works. Which is your greater temptation: to rely on your works or to neglect them? How does grace answer both?

Ephesians 4 tells us to maintain the unity of the Spirit. Is there a relationship in your church or family where you need to take the first step? What is it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are saved by grace through faith, a gift.

Rest in what Christ has done.

Ask him to keep you standing.

DAY 792 · WEEK 114

Psalm 68:1-20

God gives gifts to men, the psalm behind Ephesians 4

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 68:1-20. This is one of the most majestic psalms in the Psalter. Paul quotes verse 18 in Ephesians 4:8. Read it as a victory procession of God, and notice what God does for the lonely and the needy.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 68 is a psalm of David, probably composed for the procession of the ark into Jerusalem. It begins with the words Moses spoke when the ark set out in the wilderness (Numbers 10:35). It recalls the exodus, Sinai, the conquest, and God's reign from Zion. In Ephesians 4, Paul takes verse 18, about God ascending on high leading captives, and applies it to Christ's ascension and the gifts he gives his church.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "God shall arise, his enemies shall be scattered; and those who hate him shall flee before him!" (v. 1).
2. "But the righteous shall be glad; they shall exult before God; they shall be jubilant with joy!" (v. 3).
3. "Father of the fatherless and protector of widows is God in his holy habitation" (v. 5).
4. "God settles the solitary in a home" (v. 6).
5. "You ascended on high, leading a host of captives in your train" (v. 18).
6. "And receiving gifts among men, even among the rebellious, that the LORD God may dwell there" (v. 18).
7. "Blessed be the Lord, who daily bears us up; God is our salvation" (v. 19).

8 “Our God is a God of salvation, and to GOD, the Lord, belong deliverances from death” (v. 20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm starts with a battle cry: “God shall arise, his enemies shall be scattered.” As smoke is driven away, so he drives them away; as wax melts before fire, so the wicked perish before God. Meanwhile, “the righteous shall be glad; they shall exult before God; they shall be jubilant with joy.” The same God who is terrifying to his enemies is the joy of his people.

Then comes one of the most tender descriptions of God in the Bible: “Father of the fatherless and protector of widows is God in his holy habitation. God settles the solitary in a home; he leads out the prisoners to prosperity.” The mighty God who rides on the clouds is also the God of orphans and widows. His kingship is shown in his care for the vulnerable. The “solitary” are the lonely, and God places them in families. This is a theme of adoption, and the church is the household where it happens.

Verses 7 to 10 recall the exodus and Sinai, when the earth shook and the heavens poured down rain. God provided for his weary inheritance. Verses 11 to 14 refer to the conquest. Verses 15 to 17 describe Mount Zion, “the mount that God desired for his abode,” contrasted with the mountains of Bashan. And then the ascent: “The chariots of God are twice ten thousand, thousands upon thousands; the Lord is among them; Sinai is now in the sanctuary. You ascended on high, leading a host of captives in your train and receiving gifts among men, even among the rebellious, that the LORD God may dwell there.”

In the psalm, the picture is of a conquering king returning in triumph, with captives and tribute. Paul in Ephesians 4:8 quotes the verse with a small change: “he gave gifts to men.” Many interpreters explain that the conqueror receives tribute from the defeated and then distributes it to his people. Christ, having conquered sin, death, and Satan in the cross and resurrection, ascended and gave gifts to his church. The psalm foretold the ascension. Interestingly, the psalm adds that the gifts are received “even among the rebellious.” Even rebels are made into those who carry gifts, as Paul himself was a rebel turned apostle.

The psalm closes this section with a blessing: “Blessed be the Lord, who daily bears us up; God is our salvation.” Daily he carries his people. And “to GOD, the Lord, belong deliverances from death.” The final victory is his.

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 10:35 is the opening line of the psalm. Ephesians 4:7-16 applies verse 18. Colossians 2:15 says Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities, triumphing over them in the cross. Acts 1:9-11 and 2:33 describe the ascension and the gift of the Spirit. Psalm 146:9 and Deuteronomy 10:18 also describe God's care for the fatherless. Hebrews 4:14 and 9:24 speak of Christ entering heaven. James 1:27 says pure religion is to care for orphans and widows. Judges 5 is another victory song.

STEP 6

Application

Look for a fatherless, widowed, or lonely person in your church or community. Make a place for them.

Thank Christ for the gifts he has given you. Name one and put it to use.

Pray verse 19: bless the Lord who daily bears us up.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to rise up and scatter his enemies.
- Thank him for being father of the fatherless and defender of widows.
- Thank him for giving gifts to his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 793 · WEEK 114

Psalm 110:1-7

The priest-king who ascended on high

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110. You have read this psalm before, with Peter's sermons and Acts. Read it now with Ephesians in mind: it is the psalm of the ascended king, seated at God's right hand, who is also a priest forever.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 110 is the Old Testament verse most quoted in the New Testament. Jesus used it to stump the Pharisees (Matthew 22:41-46). Peter used it at Pentecost (Acts 2:34-35). The writer of Hebrews builds an entire argument on verse 4. In Ephesians 1:20-22, Paul draws on verse 1 when he says God seated Christ at his right hand, far above all rule and authority. Paired with Psalm 68, which describes the ascent, this psalm shows the seat and office of the ascended Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord: Sit at my right hand" (v. 1).
2. "Until I make your enemies your footstool" (v. 1).
3. "The LORD sends forth from Zion your mighty scepter" (v. 2).
4. "Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power" (v. 3).
5. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind" (v. 4).
6. "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).
7. "He will shatter kings on the day of his wrath" (v. 5).
8. "Therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a conversation within God. “The LORD says to my Lord.” David speaks of two: the LORD (Yahweh) and “my Lord” (Adonai), someone David himself calls Lord. Jesus pointed this out: “If David thus calls him Lord, how is he his son?” The answer is that the Messiah is both David’s descendant and David’s Lord, human and divine. The invitation: “Sit at my right hand, until I make your enemies your footstool.” To sit at the right hand is to share the throne. Paul says this is where Christ now is (Ephesians 1:20; Colossians 3:1).

Verse 2 says the king rules from Zion in the midst of his enemies. His reign is real now, though not yet fully visible. Verse 3 describes his people: “Your people will offer themselves freely on the day of your power.” The king’s people are volunteers, willing servants. “In holy garments” (or splendor of holiness), they come like the dew of the morning. They are a new generation, drawn by the king’s power, not forced.

Verse 4 is the astonishing center: “The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind, You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek.” In Israel, kings came from Judah and priests from Levi. But here the king is also a priest, not of the Levitical order but of Melchizedek, the mysterious priest-king of Salem who blessed Abraham (Genesis 14:18-20). The writer of Hebrews explains that Christ is a high priest of a better order, with an oath, who lives forever and therefore has a permanent priesthood. Because he is a priest-king, he can intercede for us and rule us.

Verses 5 to 7 return to the king’s victories. The Lord at your right hand “will shatter kings on the day of his wrath. He will execute judgment among the nations.” This is the final judgment. The psalm ends, “He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head.” The victorious king pauses to drink and goes on; his head is lifted in triumph. For Christians, the picture ties together the cross (the brook by the way, the suffering) and the exaltation.

Reading this psalm with Ephesians, we see that Christ’s ascension was not an absence but an enthronement. He now rules, intercedes, and gives gifts. We live between his ascension and his return, with confidence that he reigns.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 14:17-20 introduces Melchizedek. Matthew 22:41-46, Acts 2:29-36, and Hebrews 1:13, 5:6, 7:1-28 quote or use the psalm. Ephesians 1:20-23 and Colossians 3:1 speak of being seated at God’s right hand. 1 Corinthians 15:25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies

under his feet. Zechariah 6:12-13 speaks of a priest on the throne. Revelation 19:11-16 shows the victorious king. Romans 8:34 says Christ is at the right hand of God, interceding for us. Psalm 2 is a companion royal psalm.

STEP 6

Application

Remember when anxious that Christ is seated at God's right hand, ruling all things.

Give thanks that your high priest lives forever to intercede for you.

Offer yourself freely to him today, as one of the willing people of verse 3.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for sitting at the Father's right hand.
- Thank him that he is a priest forever.
- Ask him to make his enemies his footstool in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 794 · WEEK 114

Philippians 1:1-2:30

Joy in prison; the Christ hymn; Timothy and Epaphroditus

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philippians 1:1-2:30. Paul writes from prison, yet the letter is full of joy. Notice how he handles his imprisonment, the prayer he offers, the call to unity and humility, and the great Christ hymn in 2:5-11.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Philippi was a Roman colony in Macedonia where Paul planted the first church in Europe (Acts 16). The church had supported him generously. Now in prison, perhaps in Rome, he writes to thank them, to report on his situation, and to encourage them. Philippians has a repeated theme of joy; the words "joy" and "rejoice" appear about sixteen times. Its message is that joy does not depend on circumstances but on Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (1:6).
2. "I want you to know, brothers, that what has happened to me has really served to advance the gospel" (1:12).
3. "For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain" (1:21).
4. "Only let your manner of life be worthy of the gospel of Christ" (1:27).
5. "Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves" (2:3).
6. "Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus" (2:5).

7. “And every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father” (2:11).

8. “For it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure” (2:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul’s greeting includes “overseers and deacons.” He thanks God every time he remembers them, because of their partnership in the gospel from the first day. Then the great assurance of verse 6: “He who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ.” The Christian’s confidence rests on God’s faithfulness. He prays that their love may abound with knowledge and discernment, so that they may approve what is excellent and be filled with the fruit of righteousness.

Paul reports on his imprisonment. It has “really served to advance the gospel.” The whole imperial guard knows that his chains are for Christ, and most of the brothers have become more bold to speak the word without fear. Some preach Christ from envy and rivalry, others from good will. Paul’s response is remarkable: “What does it matter? Only that in every way, whether in pretense or in truth, Christ is proclaimed, and in that I rejoice.” The gospel is bigger than his reputation. Then he faces death honestly: “For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain.” He is torn between wanting to depart and be with Christ, which is far better, and remaining for their sake. He is convinced he will remain.

He calls them to unity and courage: “Only let your manner of life be worthy of the gospel of Christ… standing firm in one spirit, with one mind striving side by side for the faith of the gospel, and not frightened in anything by your opponents.” Suffering is a gift: “It has been granted to you that for the sake of Christ you should not only believe in him but also suffer for his sake.”

Then Paul calls for humility, with Christ as the model. “Do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves. Let each of you look not only to his own interests, but also to the interests of others. Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.” The hymn follows, which we will study in the next doctrinal pause: Christ, in the form of God, emptied himself, took the form of a servant, humbled himself to death on a cross; therefore God exalted him, and every knee will bow.

The practical conclusion: “Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling, for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure. Do all things without grumbling or disputing, that you may be blameless and innocent, children of God without

blemish… among whom you shine as lights in the world, holding fast to the word of life." Paul also commends Timothy, who genuinely cares for their welfare, and Epaphroditus, who nearly died for the work of Christ. These are models of Christ's mind in action.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 16:11-40 tells of the founding of the Philippian church. Isaiah 45:22-23 is the source of 2:10-11. Romans 8:28 and 2 Corinthians 4:7-12 speak of God working in suffering. Philippians 4:10-20 speaks of their gift. John 13:1-17 shows Jesus' servant act. 1 Peter 2:21-25 calls us to follow his example. 2 Corinthians 8:9 speaks of his becoming poor. Matthew 5:14-16 calls us the light of the world. Hebrews 12:1-3 points to Jesus as pioneer and perfecter.

STEP 6

Application

Read the letter with an eye for the word "joy." Count how many times it appears.

Look for a way to count someone else more significant this week.

Entrust to God a work that you worry about. He who began it will complete it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for beginning a good work in you and bringing it to completion.
- Tell him what it means that to live is Christ and to die is gain.
- Ask him to give you Christ's humility.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 795 · WEEK 114

Philippians 2:5-11; Hebrews 2:14-18

Fully God and fully man

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philippians 2:5-11 and Hebrews 2:14-18. Today is a doctrinal pause on Christ as fully God and fully man. Read the Christ hymn slowly, perhaps several times. Notice what Christ was, what he did, and what God did in response.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Philippians 2:5-11 is often called the Christ hymn, and many scholars think it is an early Christian hymn or creed that Paul quotes. Hebrews 2 makes a similar point about Christ's humanity. The church fought for centuries to express this truth precisely. At the Council of Chalcedon in AD 451, it confessed that Christ is one person in two natures, truly God and truly man, without confusion, change, division, or separation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped" (Philippians 2:6).
2. "But emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men" (Philippians 2:7).
3. "And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross" (Philippians 2:8).
4. "Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name" (Philippians 2:9).
5. "And every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:11).

6. “He himself likewise partook of the same things” (Hebrews 2:14).
7. “Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect” (Hebrews 2:17).
8. “For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted” (Hebrews 2:18).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The church confesses that Jesus Christ is fully God and fully man in one person. This is sometimes called the hypostatic union, or the doctrine of the two natures. It is the climax of the New Testament’s teaching about who Jesus is, and every other doctrine about him depends on it.

Fully God: The New Testament calls Jesus God (John 1:1; 20:28; Titus 2:13), gives him divine names, attributes, and works, and calls for worship of him. In Philippians 2:6, he existed “in the form of God” and had “equality with God.” Fully man: He was born of a woman, grew, hungered, thirsted, wept, was tempted, suffered, and died. He had a human body and a human soul. Hebrews insists he was made like us in every respect, except without sin (4:15). He is one person, not two. The same “I” who is God is the “I” who hungers.

Why does this matter? Because only a man could die for sinners, and only God could bear the infinite weight of sin and conquer death. A mediator between God and man must be both (1 Timothy 2:5). He represents us as one of us and reveals the Father as God. If Jesus is not fully God, he cannot save; if he is not fully man, he cannot save us as one of us. As Gregory of Nazianzus said, “What has not been assumed has not been healed.”

The phrase “emptied himself” (kenosis) has been debated. Orthodox interpretation holds that Christ did not cease to be God or lay aside any divine attribute, but emptied himself by taking on the form of a servant, veiling his glory, and voluntarily limiting the use of his divine prerogatives. He remained fully God while living as a real man. The main sense is not subtraction but addition: he added humanity to his deity. Some modern views claim that he gave up divine attributes; the church has rejected that as inconsistent with the biblical testimony.

The pattern of the hymn is humiliation and exaltation. He descended: from the form of God to the form of a servant, to death, to death on a cross. Then God exalted him with the name above every name, “Lord,” the name of God in the Greek Old Testament. Every knee will bow. This quotes Isaiah 45:23, where it is spoken of Yahweh. Paul applies it to Jesus.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul introduces the hymn to teach humility: “Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus.” The model of selfless love is Christ himself. “Though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped.” Christ did not hold onto the privileges of deity as something to exploit. “But emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men.” The Eternal Son took a human nature. “And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross.” Crucifixion was the most shameful death. The Son of God went all the way down.

“Therefore God has highly exalted him.” The cross was not the end. The one who humbled himself is exalted. “The name that is above every name” is likely “Lord” (verse 11). “So that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.” Notice that the exaltation of Jesus brings glory to the Father, not rivalry. The whole creation, willingly or not, will acknowledge him.

Hebrews 2 covers the same ground from a different angle. “Since therefore the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise partook of the same things, that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery.” Christ became human in order to die, and he died in order to defeat death and free us from its fear. “Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in the service of God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people. For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted.” Jesus knows our weakness from the inside. We have a sympathetic high priest.

This is the gospel in its fullest form. God did not remain at a distance. He came near, became one of us, and gave himself for us. And now the one who suffered is reigning.

STEP 5

Connection

John 1:1-18 and Colossians 1:15-20 speak of the eternal Word becoming flesh. Isaiah 45:22-25 is the source of Philippians 2:10-11. Isaiah 52:13 to 53:12 foretells the servant’s humiliation and exaltation. Hebrews 4:14-16 speaks of the sympathetic high priest. 1 Timothy 2:5 speaks of one mediator. Romans 1:3-4 mentions both natures. 2 Corinthians 8:9 speaks of his becoming poor. Luke 2:52 says Jesus increased in wisdom and stature. Mark 13:32 shows the limits of his human knowledge. Acts 2:32-36 speaks of God making him Lord and Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Read the Christ hymn aloud each morning this week. Let it shape your attitude toward others.

When you are tempted or suffering, remember that Jesus knows what it is like. Go to him.

Bow the knee. Confess aloud, "Jesus Christ is Lord."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Worship Jesus, who was in the form of God and became a servant.

Thank him for becoming fully human to save you.

Ask him to give you his mindset.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 796 · WEEK 114

Philippians 3:1-4:23

Pressing on; contentment; the peace of God

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 44 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philippians 3:1-4:23. Paul gives his own testimony, speaks of pressing on, and ends with practical commands about joy, prayer, peace, and contentment. Read 3:7-14 and 4:4-13 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In chapter 3, Paul warns the Philippians against those who trust in the flesh, including Judaizers who insisted on circumcision. He offers his own credentials and shows why he counts them as rubbish. Chapter 4 begins with a plea for two women in the church to be reconciled, followed by the best-known statements on joy, anxiety, and contentment. Paul wrote this in prison, which gives the commands special force.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Indeed, I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord" (3:8).
2. "That I may know him and the power of his resurrection, and may share his sufferings, becoming like him in his death" (3:10).
3. "I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus" (3:14).
4. "Rejoice in the Lord always; again I will say, Rejoice" (4:4).
5. "Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God" (4:6).
6. "Whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just" (4:8).
7. "I have learned in whatever situation I am to be content" (4:11).

8 “I can do all things through him who strengthens me” (4:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with a warning: “Look out for the dogs, look out for the evildoers, look out for those who mutilate the flesh. For we are the circumcision, who worship by the Spirit of God and glory in Christ Jesus and put no confidence in the flesh.” He then lists his own credentials: circumcised on the eighth day, of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews, a Pharisee, a persecutor of the church, as to righteousness under the law blameless. “But whatever gain I had, I counted as loss for the sake of Christ. Indeed, I count everything as loss because of the surpassing worth of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord. For his sake I have suffered the loss of all things and count them as rubbish, in order that I may gain Christ and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which comes through faith in Christ, the righteousness from God that depends on faith.” This is the gospel from his own heart.

The goal is to know Christ: “that I may know him and the power of his resurrection, and may share his sufferings, becoming like him in his death, that by any means possible I may attain the resurrection from the dead.” Paul has not yet arrived. “Brothers, I do not consider that I have made it my own. But one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind and straining forward to what lies ahead, I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.” Like a runner, he keeps his eyes on the finish. He calls the mature to share this mindset and to imitate him. “But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body.”

Chapter 4 opens with a plea. Euodia and Syntyche, two women who labored beside Paul in the gospel, should agree in the Lord. Then the famous passage: “Rejoice in the Lord always; again I will say, Rejoice. Let your reasonableness be known to everyone. The Lord is at hand; do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.” Anxiety is replaced by prayer, and the result is peace that stands guard. Paul then directs the mind: “Whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is commendable, if there is any excellence, if there is anything worthy of praise, think about these things.”

He thanks them for their gift and reveals the secret of contentment: “I have learned in whatever situation I am to be content. I know how to be brought low, and I know how to abound. In any and every circumstance, I have learned the secret of facing plenty and hunger, abundance and need.” The secret: “I can do all things through him who strengthens

me." This verse is often misused as a promise of success in every endeavor. In context, it means Christ gives strength to endure any circumstance, whether abundance or need. He closes with a promise: "My God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus."

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 3:21-26 and Galatians 2:15-21 expand on a righteousness from God by faith. 1 Corinthians 9:24-27 and 2 Timothy 4:7 also use the race image. Colossians 3:1-4 speaks of citizenship and the heavenly life. Matthew 6:25-34 teaches not to be anxious. 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast all your anxieties on him. 1 Timothy 6:6-10 speaks of godliness with contentment. Hebrews 13:5 says be content with what you have. 2 Corinthians 12:9-10 gives Christ's strength in weakness. Isaiah 26:3 promises perfect peace.

STEP 6

Application

When anxiety comes, turn each worry into a specific prayer with thanksgiving.

Think on the list of verse 8 for ten minutes. Write down things that fit each description.

Ask what you need to count as loss for the sake of knowing Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell Jesus that you count everything as loss compared to knowing him.
- Ask him to help you press on toward the goal.
- Give him your anxieties with thanksgiving.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 797 · WEEK 114

Colossians 1:1-2:5

Christ above all; the cosmic Christ; the mystery

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Colossians 1:1-2:5. This is the great passage on the supremacy of Christ. Read verses 15-20 slowly and several times. Then notice how Paul describes his own ministry of suffering and labor.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul wrote Colossians from prison to a church he had not founded, in a town in the Lycus Valley near Laodicea and Hierapolis. Epaphras had planted the church and brought news of a developing heresy. The false teaching mixed Jewish regulations, mystical visions, angel worship, and ascetic practices with a diminished view of Christ. Paul's answer is not a list of rules but a magnificent portrait of Christ as supreme over everything.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son" (1:13).
2. "He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation" (1:15).
3. "For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible" (1:16).
4. "And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together" (1:17).
5. "And he is the head of the body, the church. He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in everything he might be preeminent" (1:18).
6. "Making peace by the blood of his cross" (1:20).
7. "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (1:27).

8 “In whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (2:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul greets the church, thanks God for their faith, love, and hope, and prays that they would be filled with the knowledge of God’s will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding, to walk in a manner worthy of the Lord, fully pleasing to him, bearing fruit, increasing in the knowledge of God, strengthened with all power, joyfully giving thanks to the Father. And he states what God has done: “He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.”

Then the hymn to Christ in verses 15 to 20. In the first stanza, Christ is supreme over creation. “He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities, all things were created through him and for him. And he is before all things, and in him all things hold together.” “Image” means that he perfectly shows God. “Firstborn” is a title of rank and inheritance, not of being created: he is the heir and sovereign over creation, as the creator of it. Everything was made by him, through him, and for him. He holds the universe together. No angel, spirit, or power rivals him.

In the second stanza, Christ is supreme over the new creation. “He is the head of the body, the church. He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, that in everything he might be preeminent. For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.” The creator is the redeemer. The same Christ who made all things is reconciling all things. The cross is the means of cosmic peace. Notice that “all the fullness of God” dwells in him.

Then Paul applies it to the Colossians: once alienated and hostile in mind, doing evil deeds, they have been reconciled in his body of flesh by his death, “in order to present you holy and blameless and above reproach before him, if indeed you continue in the faith.” Perseverance is the evidence of reality.

Paul describes his own ministry. He rejoices in his sufferings for their sake, “and in my flesh I am filling up what is lacking in Christ’s afflictions for the sake of his body, that is, the church.” This does not mean Christ’s atonement is incomplete; rather, Paul’s sufferings as an apostle extend Christ’s afflictions into the world as the gospel is spread. The mystery now revealed is “Christ in you, the hope of glory.” He proclaims Christ, warning everyone and teaching everyone in all wisdom, that he may present everyone mature in Christ. Chapter 2

begins with his struggle for them, that their hearts may be encouraged, knit together in love, to reach all the riches of full assurance of understanding and of knowing the mystery of God, "in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge."

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1 and Proverbs 8:22-31 stand behind the creation language. John 1:1-3 and Hebrews 1:1-4 are parallel statements. Isaiah 45:18 and Psalm 33:6 speak of God as creator. Revelation 1:5 calls Jesus the firstborn of the dead. Romans 8:19-23 speaks of creation's renewal. Ephesians 1:10 and 2:11-22 speak of uniting all things. 2 Corinthians 5:18-21 speaks of reconciliation. Philippians 2:5-11 is a related hymn. Galatians 2:20 speaks of Christ living in us.

STEP 6

Application

Read Colossians 1:15-20 aloud once a day this week. Let it enlarge your view of Christ.

Where do you feel small in the face of problems? Remember that he holds all things together.

Ask what it means for you that Christ is "preeminent in everything." What area of your life does he not yet lead?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship Jesus as the image of the invisible God.
- Thank him that in him all things hold together.
- Tell him what you want to give him preeminence over.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 114

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

DAY 798 · WEEK 114

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Philippians 4:6-7 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

PHILIPPIANS 4:6-7

REST

Meditation

These verses are Paul's prescription for anxiety. They are written by a man in prison.

"Do not be anxious about anything." The command is wide: about anything. Paul does not say that we will never feel worry, but that we should not live in it. Anxiety divides the mind and assumes that everything depends on us.

"But in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving." The alternative to worry is prayer. Prayer is the general word; supplication is the specific asking for needs. Thanksgiving is included, because it reminds us of God's faithfulness in the past and shifts our focus from what we lack.

“Let your requests be made known to God.” Be specific. God knows already, but he invites us to say it. Bring the actual worries by name.

“And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.” Notice the promise: it is not that the circumstances will necessarily change but that peace will stand guard like a soldier at the gate. It is a peace that does not make sense from the outside. It is found “in Christ Jesus.”

When anxiety rises, pray this verse, and turn each worry into a request with thanks.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you moved from Ephesians into Philippians and Colossians. Psalms 68 and 110 showed the ascended Christ, who leads captives, gives gifts, and sits at God’s right hand as priest-king. Philippians showed joy in prison: the gospel advances through chains, Christ is the model of humility, and God works in us both to will and to work. A doctrinal pause on the Christ hymn considered that Jesus is fully God and fully man in one person, who emptied himself, took the form of a servant, and was exalted to the name above every name. Philippians 3 and 4 showed the surpassing worth of knowing Christ, pressing on toward the goal, praying instead of worrying, and the secret of contentment in Christ who strengthens us. Colossians 1 and 2 presented the supremacy of Christ: image of the invisible God, creator and sustainer of all things, head of the church, reconciler by the blood of his cross, and Christ in us, the hope of glory.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says to be anxious about nothing and to pray about everything. What is one worry you need to turn into a specific prayer right now? Take a few minutes and do it.

Colossians 1:15-20 says Christ is supreme over creation and over the church. Where in your life do you treat Christ as less than preeminent? What would it look like to give him first place?

Philippians 3 says Paul counted all his credentials as loss for the sake of knowing Christ. What do you trust in besides Christ for your standing, identity, or security? What would it look like to let it go?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for being supreme and for being your peace.

Thank him for the peace of God that guards your heart and mind.

Rest in him.

DAY 799 · WEEK 115

Colossians 2:6-3:17

Don't be taken captive; the new self; let Christ's word dwell

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Colossians 2:6-3:17. Paul warns against being taken captive by empty philosophy and then gives the positive vision: you have died and been raised with Christ, so put off the old and put on the new. Read 3:1-17 slowly, as a portrait of the Christian life.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After exalting Christ in chapter 1, Paul addresses the false teaching in Colosse. It seems to have included regulations about food, drink, festivals, and Sabbaths; visions and worship of angels; and severe treatment of the body. Paul's answer is that all of this is only a shadow, and the substance is Christ. Then he turns to the new life, which is based on union with Christ in his death and resurrection.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "See to it that no one takes you captive by philosophy and empty deceit, according to human tradition" (2:8).
2. "For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily" (2:9).
3. "By canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands" (2:14).
4. "These are a shadow of the things to come, but the substance belongs to Christ" (2:17).
5. "If then you have been raised with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God" (3:1).
6. "For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God" (3:3).
7. "And above all these put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony" (3:14).

8 “Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and admonishing one another in all wisdom” (3:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with the basic instruction: “As you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in him, rooted and built up in him and established in the faith, just as you were taught, abounding in thanksgiving.” The Christian life continues as it began: with Christ. Then the warning: “See to it that no one takes you captive by philosophy and empty deceit, according to human tradition, according to the elemental spirits of the world, and not according to Christ.” Not all philosophy is wrong, but any teaching that adds to or displaces Christ is empty. The reason: “For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily, and you have been filled in him, who is the head of all rule and authority.” If you have Christ, you have everything.

Next, what Christ has done. In him you were circumcised with a circumcision made without hands, buried with him in baptism and raised with him through faith in the powerful working of God. “And you, who were dead in your trespasses… God made alive together with him, having forgiven us all our trespasses, by canceling the record of debt that stood against us with its legal demands. This he set aside, nailing it to the cross.” The debt-record that condemned us was nailed to the cross. “He disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame, by triumphing over them in him.” The powers have been defeated.

So Paul says: “Let no one pass judgment on you in questions of food and drink, or with regard to a festival or a new moon or a Sabbath. These are a shadow of the things to come, but the substance belongs to Christ.” The old covenant regulations pointed forward to Christ, and now that the reality has come, we are not bound to the shadow. This is a significant text in understanding the relationship between the covenants. Christians differ on how it bears on the Sabbath, but all agree it clarifies that no ritual observance contributes to our standing before God. Rules that appear wise, like “Do not handle, Do not taste, Do not touch,” have no value in stopping the indulgence of the flesh.

Chapter 3 begins with “If then you have been raised with Christ.” The resurrection has practical consequences. “Seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth. For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God. When Christ who is your life appears, then you also will appear with him in glory.” Our true life is secured in heaven.

Then the practical: “Put to death therefore what is earthly in you: sexual immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry.” Put away anger, wrath, malice, slander, obscene talk, and lying. These belong to the old self. “Put on then, as God’s

chosen ones, holy and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, and patience, bearing with one another and, if one has a complaint against another, forgiving each other; as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive. And above all these put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony. And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts." Finally, "Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly, teaching and admonishing one another in all wisdom, singing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, with thankfulness in your hearts to God. And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

STEP 5

Connection

Romans 6:1-14 speaks of union with Christ in death and resurrection. Ephesians 4:17-32 and Galatians 5:16-26 are parallels on putting off and putting on. Isaiah 61:10 speaks of being clothed in righteousness. Hebrews 8:5, 10:1 describe the law as a shadow. Mark 7:14-23 shows Jesus on clean and unclean. Matthew 6:19-21 says set your treasure in heaven. 1 Peter 2:9 speaks of God's chosen ones. Philippians 3:20-21 speaks of heavenly citizenship. Psalm 119:11 speaks of treasuring the word.

STEP 6

Application

Read Colossians 3:12-17 aloud as a list of clothes. Put on one piece today.

Set your mind on things above for a few minutes at the start of the day.

Ask what "rules" you have made that are not from Christ. Where do you trust a shadow?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that in him the whole fullness of deity dwells, and that you have been filled in him.

Ask him to help you set your mind on things above.

Ask him to let his word dwell in you richly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

“And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.”

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 800 · WEEK 115

Colossians 3:18–4:18

Household codes; final greetings

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Colossians 3:18-4:18. Paul gives instructions for households and for the church's witness, then ends with a long list of greetings. Notice the Christ-centered grounds of each command and the picture of the church as a network of friends and coworkers.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul has described the new life in Christ in general terms. Now he applies it to the most ordinary relationships of daily life: marriage, parents and children, work. He addresses each party in the relationship, treating all as accountable to the Lord. This is a significant feature: the instructions about households, which echo Ephesians 5 and 6, give moral responsibility to all, including children and slaves, and warn masters. The letter ends with a list of names that shows the early church as a living community.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Husbands, love your wives, and do not be harsh with them" (3:19).
2. "Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men" (3:23).
3. "Masters, treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven" (4:1).
4. "Continue steadfastly in prayer, being watchful in it with thanksgiving" (4:2).
5. "At the same time pray also for us, that God may open to us a door for the word, to declare the mystery of Christ" (4:3).
6. "Let your speech always be gracious, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how you ought to answer each person" (4:6).

7. “Luke the beloved physician greets you” (4:14).

8. “Remember my chains. Grace be with you” (4:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The household code in Colossians is shorter than in Ephesians but follows the same pattern. “Wives, submit to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord. Husbands, love your wives, and do not be harsh with them.” The word for “harsh” means bitter or embittered. The husband’s role is love, not domination. “Children, obey your parents in everything, for this pleases the Lord. Fathers, do not provoke your children, lest they become discouraged.” Discouragement is a real danger in children, and fathers are responsible not to cause it.

To slaves, Paul gives the longest instruction. “Bondservants, obey in everything those who are your earthly masters, not with eye-service, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord. Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the inheritance as your reward. You are serving the Lord Christ.” This is a transformative vision of work, which we will explore on the doctrinal pause. “For the wrongdoer will be paid back for the wrong he has done, and there is no partiality.” Then to masters: “treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven.” Paul does not endorse slavery. He addresses people within a social system and weakens it from within, as Philemon will show.

Paul then calls the church to prayer and witness. “Continue steadfastly in prayer, being watchful in it with thanksgiving.” He asks for prayer for himself and his coworkers: “that God may open to us a door for the word, to declare the mystery of Christ, on account of which I am in prison, that I may make it clear, which is how I ought to speak.” Imprisoned, he does not pray for release but for opportunities to preach. And the church’s own witness: “Walk in wisdom toward outsiders, making the best use of the time. Let your speech always be gracious, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how you ought to answer each person.” Gracious, not flat; seasoned, not bland.

The closing section is a roll call. Tychicus, “a beloved brother and faithful minister and fellow servant in the Lord,” will tell them everything about Paul, with Onesimus, “who is one of you.” Aristarchus, Mark (the cousin of Barnabas, now restored to Paul’s favor), Jesus called Justus. Epaphras, who is “always struggling on your behalf in his prayers.” Luke the beloved physician, and Demas, who will later desert him (2 Timothy 4:10). Nympha and the church in her house. And a message for Archippus: “See that you fulfill the ministry that you have received in the Lord.” The letter ends: “I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand. Remember my chains. Grace be with you.” Behind the doctrine are people with names and stories.

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 5:22 to 6:9 is the parallel. 1 Peter 2:18 to 3:7 also addresses households. Philemon applies the teaching to a specific case. Acts 12:12 and 15:36-41 tell of Mark. Acts 20:4 mentions Tychicus. 2 Timothy 4:10-11 mentions Demas and Luke. Philemon 23-24 repeats several of these names. Revelation 3:14-22 addresses Laodicea. Proverbs 15:1 and 25:11 speak of wise speech. Luke 12:35-48 speaks of service to the master.

STEP 6

Application

Name the people in your life whom you serve in a relationship of authority or dependence. Treat each as someone who answers to the Lord.

Pray for a door for the gospel with someone this week. Pray also for your speech to be gracious and salty.

Write a note of thanks to a faithful fellow worker, like Tychicus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you do whatever you do heartily, as for him.
- Ask him to bless your household and your workplace.
- Ask him to give you wisdom and gracious words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 801 · WEEK 115

1 Corinthians 7:17-24; Colossians 3:22-4:1

Ordinary work as service to God

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Corinthians 7:17-24 and Colossians 3:22-4:1. Today is a doctrinal pause on ordinary work as service to God, also called vocation or calling. Notice that Paul speaks to people whose jobs were not their choice, and he still says that they serve the Lord Christ.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Most Christians spend most of their waking hours at work, in the home, or in the community, not in church. What does the gospel say about that? In the first century, a large portion of believers were slaves or workers in humble occupations. Paul does not tell them that real service to God is elsewhere. He tells them that their ordinary labor, done for Christ, is service to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him” (1 Corinthians 7:17).
2. “For he who was called in the Lord as a bondservant is a freedman of the Lord” (1 Corinthians 7:22).
3. “You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men” (1 Corinthians 7:23).
4. “So, brothers, in whatever condition each was called, there let him remain with God” (1 Corinthians 7:24).

5. “Not with eye-service, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord” (Colossians 3:22).
6. “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men” (Colossians 3:23).
7. “You are serving the Lord Christ” (Colossians 3:24).
8. “Masters, treat your bondservants justly and fairly, knowing that you also have a Master in heaven” (Colossians 4:1).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The doctrine of vocation says that God calls his people not only to salvation but also to places of service in the world, and that ordinary work is a way of loving God and neighbor. The word “calling” in the New Testament primarily refers to God’s call to salvation in Christ, as in 1 Corinthians 7:17-24, where Paul speaks of the condition in which each was called. By extension, Christians have understood that God also places us in occupations, families, churches, and communities where we serve him.

During the Reformation, Martin Luther emphasized that the farmer, the mother, the magistrate, and the cobbler serve God as much as the monk or priest. Before, many believed that spiritual work was reserved for clergy. Luther said that God milks cows through the hands of milkmaids. The Reformers taught that all legitimate work is a calling, and that we serve God by serving others in it. In the Reformed tradition, this became a doctrine of the cultural mandate: from Genesis 1:28 and 2:15, human beings were made to work, tend, and cultivate the creation. Work was part of paradise; the fall made it toilsome (Genesis 3:17-19), but redemption restores its dignity.

Three truths follow. First, the Lord is the real boss. “You are serving the Lord Christ.” This gives dignity to menial jobs and removes the excuse of poor management, since our ultimate employer sees and rewards. Second, work is for others. Ephesians 4:28 says the thief should work with his hands “so that he may have something to share with anyone in need.” Work serves the neighbor and the common good. Third, our identity is not in our work. We are first called to Christ. This frees us from both pride in achievement and despair in failure.

The passage on slavery requires care. Paul is not endorsing slavery as an institution. The New Testament never commands it and regards the slave trade as sin (1 Timothy 1:10). He gives instructions to people living within it. At the same time, he undermines it: slaves are addressed as moral agents with an inheritance from the Lord, masters are told they have a Master in heaven, and in 1 Corinthians 7:21 he adds, “if you can gain your freedom, avail

yourself of the opportunity." Philemon, which you will read soon, calls a master to receive a slave as a beloved brother. The Christian gospel, taken to its conclusion, led believers to oppose slavery.

Christians also differ on how much to emphasize staying in one's condition (1 Corinthians 7:20, 24) versus pursuing change. Paul's point is that your condition does not determine your standing with God, not that you can never change it.

STEP 4

Interpretation

In 1 Corinthians 7, Paul has been addressing marriage and singleness. He gives a general rule: "Only let each person lead the life that the Lord has assigned to him, and to which God has called him. This is my rule in all the churches." Circumcised or uncircumcised, it does not matter; keeping God's commandments is what matters. "Each one should remain in the condition in which he was called." Were you a slave when called? "Do not be concerned about it. (But if you can gain your freedom, avail yourself of the opportunity.) For he who was called in the Lord as a bondservant is a freedman of the Lord. Likewise he who was free when called is a bondservant of Christ. You were bought with a price; do not become slaves of men." The gospel gives a new status that cannot be taken away. A slave is the Lord's freedman; a free person is Christ's slave. The social ranking is secondary.

In Colossians 3, Paul turns to practical conduct. "Bondservants, obey in everything those who are your earthly masters, not with eye-service, as people-pleasers, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord." Eye-service is working only when the boss is watching. "Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the inheritance as your reward. You are serving the Lord Christ." The slave had no legal rights, but Paul tells him that he has an inheritance, which the free would normally receive. The reward is not wages but the inheritance of the sons of God. In a world where slaves were considered tools, this was radical.

The principle applies to every honest job. Whatever you do, do it heartily. The Christian employee, student, parent, teacher, cleaner, or executive works for a higher Lord. This changes how we work (with diligence), why we work (for his glory and others' good), and how we rest (in his provision). Mundane tasks are holy when done to the Lord.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:28 and 2:15 give the work mandate. Genesis 3:17-19 describes the toil after the fall. Exodus 31:1-6 describes the Spirit-filled craftsmen. Proverbs 6:6-11 and 22:29 praise diligent work. Ephesians 4:28 and 6:5-9 speak of work and slaves. 2 Thessalonians 3:6-12 warns

against idleness. 1 Corinthians 10:31 says do all to the glory of God. Philemon is the test case. Psalm 90:17 prays for the work of our hands to be established. Matthew 25:14-30 teaches faithfulness in what we have been given.

STEP 6

Application

Do your next task today as if Christ were your employer. Notice what changes.

Thank God for the occupation he has given you, even if it's imperfect.

Think about someone whose work is invisible, like a janitor or a caregiver. Honor them this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the work he has given you, and tell him what it is.
- Ask him to help you work heartily, as for the Lord.
- Ask him to show you how your ordinary work can serve him and others.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 802 · WEEK 115

1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13

A model church; Paul's care; the apostle's heart

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Thessalonians 1:1-3:13. This is probably Paul's earliest letter. Read it as a warm letter from a spiritual father to young believers. Notice the model they set, the way Paul describes his ministry, and the way he longs to see them.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul planted the church in Thessalonica, the capital of Macedonia, on his second journey (Acts 17:1-9). He stayed only a few weeks before being driven out by a mob. Anxious about the young believers, he sent Timothy back; when Timothy returned with good news, Paul wrote this letter from Corinth around AD 50. It is full of encouragement, with gratitude, defense of his ministry against slander, and comfort. The Thessalonians were facing persecution and questions about those who had died.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Remembering before our God and Father your work of faith and labor of love and steadfastness of hope in our Lord Jesus Christ" (1:3).
2. "Because our gospel came to you not only in word, but also in power and in the Holy Spirit and with full conviction" (1:5).
3. "How you turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God, and to wait for his Son from heaven" (1:9-10).
4. "But we were gentle among you, like a nursing mother taking care of her own children" (2:7).
5. "We were ready to share with you not only the gospel of God but also our own selves" (2:8).

6. “You accepted it not as the word of men but as what it really is, the word of God, which is at work in you believers” (2:13).
7. “For now we live, if you are standing fast in the Lord” (3:8).
8. “And may the Lord make you increase and abound in love for one another and for all” (3:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The letter opens with thanksgiving. Paul remembers their “work of faith and labor of love and steadfastness of hope,” the great triad of faith, love, and hope. He knows God chose them because the gospel came “not only in word, but also in power and in the Holy Spirit and with full conviction.” They became imitators of Paul and the Lord, receiving the word in much affliction with the joy of the Holy Spirit, and became an example to all the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. The word of the Lord sounded forth from them. Everyone reports how they “turned to God from idols to serve the living and true God, and to wait for his Son from heaven, whom he raised from the dead, Jesus who delivers us from the wrath to come.” A model church: converted, serving, and waiting.

In chapter 2, Paul describes his ministry. The accusations probably were that he was a charlatan who preached for money or praise. He replies with the facts: they were bold to speak the gospel in spite of suffering at Philippi. They did not speak with error or impure motives or deceit. They were not trying to please men but God who tests the heart. They did not use flattery or greed or seek glory. “But we were gentle among you, like a nursing mother taking care of her own children.” Then, as a father, “exhorting each one of you and encouraging you and charging you to walk in a manner worthy of God, who calls you into his own kingdom and glory.” Paul’s ministry combines maternal tenderness and paternal firmness. They worked night and day so as not to burden anyone.

“And we also thank God constantly for this, that when you received the word of God, which you heard from us, you accepted it not as the word of men but as what it really is, the word of God, which is at work in you believers.” This is a key statement about preaching: faithful preaching of Scripture is the word of God. The Thessalonians suffered from their own countrymen, as the churches in Judea did from the Jews. Paul longed to see them and was hindered by Satan. “For what is our hope or joy or crown of boasting before our Lord Jesus at his coming? Is it not you?”

In chapter 3, Paul explains that he sent Timothy to strengthen them in their faith, lest they be shaken by afflictions. When Timothy returned with news of their faith and love, Paul was comforted. “For now we live, if you are standing fast in the Lord.” The prayer: “Now may our God and Father himself, and our Lord Jesus, direct our way to you, and may the Lord make

you increase and abound in love for one another and for all, as we do for you, so that he may establish your hearts blameless in holiness before our God and Father, at the coming of our Lord Jesus with all his saints." Ministry is love expressed in prayer and labor.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 17:1-15 tells of the Thessalonian mission. Philippians 4:15-16 mentions their gifts. 2 Corinthians 11:9 records provision from Macedonia. 1 Corinthians 13:13 pairs faith, hope, and love. Hebrews 4:12 speaks of the word of God living and active. 2 Timothy 3:16-17 teaches that all Scripture is God-breathed. Matthew 24:13 and John 15:18-20 speak of enduring persecution. Romans 8:35-39 assures of Christ's love in suffering. Colossians 1:3-8 reflects similar thanksgiving.

STEP 6

Application

Thank someone who led you to Christ or taught you in the faith. Tell them.

Ask whether you are a model for others, in how you turned to God, serve, and wait.

Receive Scripture today as the word of God, which is at work in you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for people who work in faith, labor in love, and endure in hope.

Ask him to help you be that kind of person.

Thank him for those who showed you how.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 803 · WEEK 115

1 Thessalonians 4:13-18; Matthew 24:30-31; Revelation 1:7

The Return of Christ

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18, Matthew 24:30-31, and Revelation 1:7. Today is a doctrinal pause on the return of Christ. Notice how Paul comforts grieving believers, and how Jesus and John describe his coming.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first Christians lived in expectation of Christ's return. The Thessalonians, new believers, were distressed because some of their number had died before he returned. Would they miss out? Paul writes to correct their ignorance and to comfort them. The second coming of Christ is one of the most frequently repeated promises of the New Testament, and it shapes how Christians live, pray, grieve, and hope.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But we do not want you to be uninformed, brothers, about those who are asleep, that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope" (1 Thessalonians 4:13).
2. "For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep" (1 Thessalonians 4:14).
3. "For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God" (1 Thessalonians 4:16).
4. "Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord" (1 Thessalonians 4:17).

5. “Therefore encourage one another with these words” (1 Thessalonians 4:18).
6. “Then will appear in heaven the sign of the Son of Man” (Matthew 24:30).
7. “And he will send out his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds” (Matthew 24:31).
8. “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him” (Revelation 1:7).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The return of Christ, often called the second coming, is the promise that Jesus will come again, personally, visibly, bodily, and gloriously, at the end of the age, to raise the dead, judge the world, and establish his kingdom in its fullness. The angels said at the ascension, “This Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven” (Acts 1:11). It is the “blessed hope” of the church (Titus 2:13).

Several features are clear. It will be personal: “the Lord himself will descend.” It will be visible and public: “every eye will see him.” It will be glorious, with a cry of command, the voice of an archangel, and the trumpet of God. It will be sudden: “like a thief in the night.” The timing is unknown: not even the angels or the Son know the day or hour (Matthew 24:36). Therefore we are to be ready and watchful. It will bring the resurrection of believers and the transformation of those still alive. It will bring judgment on the living and the dead, and it will complete salvation: the new creation, the end of death, and God dwelling with his people.

Christians have held different views about the details, especially regarding the “rapture” (being caught up in the air) and the millennium. Some hold that Christ will return before a thousand-year reign (premillennialism), with differing views on whether the church goes through the great tribulation. Others hold that the millennium is the present reign of Christ in heaven and with his church (amillennialism). Others hold that the church will bring about a golden age before his return (postmillennialism). These differences matter less than the shared hope: Christ is coming, visibly, to raise the dead, judge, and make all things new. We should hold such details with humility and avoid date-setting.

The doctrine has practical effects. It comforts the grieving: we will see our loved ones in Christ again. It motivates holiness: “everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself as he is pure” (1 John 3:3). It encourages mission, because the gospel must be preached to all nations before the end. It also sobers us because judgment is coming. And it makes us watchful and active.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul writes, “We do not want you to be uninformed, brothers, about those who are asleep, that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope.” Christians do grieve, but not as those without hope. “For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep.” The resurrection of Jesus is the guarantee of ours.

Then he explains by “a word from the Lord”: “We who are alive, who are left until the coming of the Lord, will not precede those who have fallen asleep. For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord.” The picture is of a welcoming party: when a king visited a city, citizens went out to meet him and escort him back in. We rise to meet the Lord and come with him. “Therefore encourage one another with these words.” The doctrine of Christ’s return is meant for comfort.

Jesus himself speaks in Matthew 24 of the sign of the Son of Man appearing in heaven, and all the tribes of the earth mourning as they see the Son of Man coming on the clouds with power and great glory. He will send out his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds. This echoes Daniel 7:13-14. For those who have rejected him, his coming means mourning; for his people, it means gathering.

John, in Revelation 1:7, combines Daniel 7:13 and Zechariah 12:10: “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him, and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him. Even so. Amen.” The same Jesus who was pierced will return. The right response is to say “Amen” and “Come, Lord Jesus.”

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14 and Zechariah 12:10 stand behind the language. Acts 1:9-11 gives the promise at the ascension. Matthew 24:36 to 25:46 includes Jesus’ teaching on being ready. John 14:1-3 promises, “I will come again and take you to myself.” 1 Corinthians 15:51-58 describes the change. Philippians 3:20-21 speaks of our heavenly citizenship. Titus 2:11-14 speaks of the blessed hope. 2 Peter 3:3-13 answers scoffers. Revelation 19:11-16 and 22:20 describe his coming and the church’s cry.

STEP 6

Application

Share verse 18 with someone who is grieving: “Encourage one another with these words.”

Ask whether you live as if Christ may come today. What would you change?

Pray, “Come, Lord Jesus,” as part of your prayers this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he will return with a shout.
- Tell him how you feel about his coming, and ask him to make you ready.
- Ask him to give you hope and comfort for those who have died in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

“And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.”

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 804 · WEEK 115

1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28

Holy living; the coming of the Lord; final exhortations

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Thessalonians 4:1-5:28. Paul gives instruction on holy living, brotherly love, the day of the Lord, and a series of brief final exhortations. Notice how many of the commands are short and practical.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having celebrated the church and defended his ministry, Paul turns to instruction. He urges the Thessalonians to live in holiness, to love one another, and to work quietly. Then, after the comfort of 4:13-18, he adds a warning and encouragement about the day of the Lord: how to live in the meantime. The letter ends with a rapid-fire list of commands that summarize the Christian life.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “And to aspire to live quietly, and to mind your own affairs, and to work with your hands” (4:11).
2. “For you yourselves are fully aware that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night” (5:2).
3. “But since we belong to the day, let us be sober, having put on the breastplate of faith and love, and for a helmet the hope of salvation” (5:8).
4. “For God has not destined us for wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ” (5:9).
5. “Therefore encourage one another and build one another up, just as you are doing” (5:11).

6. “Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances” (5:16-18).
7. “Test everything; hold fast what is good” (5:21).
8. “He who calls you is faithful; he will surely do it” (5:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 opens with a call to please God more and more. “For this is the will of God, your sanctification: that you abstain from sexual immorality; that each of you know how to control his own body in holiness and honor.” God has called us in holiness, and he gives his Holy Spirit. Regarding brotherly love, Paul says they have been taught by God and are doing it, but to do so more and more. He adds a practical word: “aspire to live quietly, and to mind your own affairs, and to work with your hands, as we instructed you, so that you may walk properly before outsiders and be dependent on no one.” Some had apparently stopped working in expectation of Christ’s return. Hope does not cancel responsibility.

After the passage on the return of Christ (see the doctrinal pause), chapter 5 addresses “the times and the seasons.” Believers do not need instruction about dates, “for you yourselves are fully aware that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night. While people are saying, There is peace and security, then sudden destruction will come upon them.” But believers are not in darkness. “For you are all children of light, children of the day.” So the response: “Let us not sleep, as others do, but let us keep awake and be sober.” The armor is faith and love as a breastplate and the hope of salvation as a helmet. “For God has not destined us for wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ, who died for us so that whether we are awake or asleep we might live with him. Therefore encourage one another and build one another up.”

Then a rapid series of commands. Respect those who labor among you and are over you in the Lord; esteem them highly in love because of their work. Be at peace among yourselves. Admonish the idle, encourage the fainthearted, help the weak, be patient with all. “See that no one repays anyone evil for evil, but always seek to do good to one another and to everyone.” And the famous three: “Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.” These are not a requirement to feel happy always but a settled posture toward God. “Do not quench the Spirit. Do not despise prophecies, but test everything; hold fast what is good. Abstain from every form of evil.”

The prayer: “Now may the God of peace himself sanctify you completely, and may your whole spirit and soul and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. He who calls you is faithful; he will surely do it.” Holiness is ultimately God’s work. The letter

ends: “Pray for us. Greet all the brothers with a holy kiss. I put you under oath before the Lord to have this letter read to all the brothers. The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you.”

STEP 5

Connection

Leviticus 19:2 and 1 Peter 1:15-16 call for holiness. John 13:34-35 gives the new commandment. 2 Thessalonians 3:6-13 deals with idleness. Matthew 24:42-44 compares the coming to a thief. Ephesians 6:13-17 describes the armor. Philippians 4:4-7 is a parallel on joy and prayer. Luke 18:1 and Colossians 4:2 speak of constant prayer. 1 John 4:1 says to test the spirits. Hebrews 13:7, 17 speak of leaders. Philippians 1:6 and Jude 24 assure of God’s keeping.

STEP 6

Application

Pick one of the short commands in 5:14-22 and practice it today.

Practice thanks in all circumstances: list three things for which to give thanks right now, even in hard times.

Ask what “quiet” work you can do faithfully, and do it as for the Lord.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to sanctify you completely and keep you blameless.
- Ask him to help you encourage someone with the hope of his coming.
- Tell him what you want to hold on to as you wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 115

“And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him.”

COLOSSIANS 3:17

DAY 805 · WEEK 115

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Colossians 3:17 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."

COLOSSIANS 3:17

REST

Meditation

This verse is a summary of a whole way of life.

"And whatever you do." The scope is total. Not just the religious parts of life, but everything. Eating, working, speaking, parenting, driving, resting.

"In word or deed." Our speech and our actions both. Together they make up the whole of what we show the world.

"Do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus." To act in someone's name is to act on his authority and on his behalf. A Christian is an ambassador. We represent Christ in every place. We ask: Would he put his name on this? Does this honor him?

"Giving thanks to God the Father through him." The attitude is gratitude. Everything we have comes from the Father through the Son. Thanksgiving turns ordinary tasks into worship.

This verse removes the divide between sacred and secular. A meal can be a prayer, a job can be worship, a conversation can be ministry.

When your day feels ordinary or scattered, say this verse. Offer it all in his name, with thanks.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished Colossians and read 1 Thessalonians. Colossians 2 and 3 warned against empty philosophy and human tradition and taught that the old covenant regulations were a shadow whose substance is Christ. Because we have been raised with Christ, we seek the things above, put off the old self, put on compassion, kindness, humility, and love, and let the word of Christ dwell in us richly. Chapter 3 and 4 applied this to households, work, prayer, and speech. A doctrinal pause considered ordinary work as service to the Lord Christ. First Thessalonians presented a model church that turned from idols to serve the living God and wait for his Son, a pastor's tender heart, comfort for those who grieve, and a series of final commands: rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances. A doctrinal pause on the return of Christ affirmed that he will come again to raise the dead and gather his people.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Colossians 3:23 says to work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men. What task in your week do you do half-heartedly? How might you do it differently if you remembered who your real Master is?

Paul told the Thessalonians not to grieve as those who have no hope. Who is someone you could comfort with the hope of Christ's return and the resurrection? What will you say or do?

First Thessalonians 5:16-18 gives three short commands: rejoice, pray, give thanks. Which is hardest for you right now? What might help you practice it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Offer what you do this week to God, giving thanks to the Father through Jesus.

Thank him that Christ is coming.

Rest in his faithfulness.

DAY 806 · WEEK 116

Psalm 27

I believe I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 27. It is a psalm of David that begins with confidence and moves into a plea. Notice the one thing David asks for, and how the psalm ends with an exhortation to wait.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 27 is a psalm of David, probably from a time of danger from enemies. It has two parts: verses 1 to 6 are a song of trust, and verses 7 to 14 are a prayer for help. It fits our reading in 1 Thessalonians, where believers faced persecution, and in the Prison Epistles, where Paul writes from chains. The psalm teaches us that confidence in God and honest prayer belong together.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear?” (v. 1).
2. “Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear” (v. 3).
3. “One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life” (v. 4).
4. “To gaze upon the beauty of the LORD and to inquire in his temple” (v. 4).
5. “For he will hide me in his shelter in the day of trouble” (v. 5).
6. “You have said, Seek my face. My heart says to you, Your face, LORD, do I seek” (v. 8).
7. “For my father and my mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take me in” (v. 10).
8. “I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!” (v. 13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David begins with three titles for God: light, salvation, and stronghold. “The LORD is my light and my salvation; whom shall I fear? The LORD is the stronghold of my life; of whom shall I be afraid?” Light dispels darkness, salvation rescues, stronghold protects. When evildoers assail him to eat up his flesh, they stumble and fall. “Though an army encamp against me, my heart shall not fear; though war arise against me, yet I will be confident.” The confidence is not in himself but in the LORD.

Then the heart of the psalm: “One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD and to inquire in his temple.” Of all that he could ask, David asks for one thing: God’s presence. This is the great desire of the believer. In the temple, he gazes on the beauty of the LORD. The dwelling place of God is the source of safety: “For he will hide me in his shelter in the day of trouble; he will conceal me under the cover of his tent; he will lift me high upon a rock.” The result is joy: “I will offer in his tent sacrifices with shouts of joy; I will sing and make melody to the LORD.”

The second half is a prayer. “Hear, O LORD, when I cry aloud; be gracious to me and answer me!” David recalls God’s call: “You have said, Seek my face. My heart says to you, Your face, LORD, do I seek. Hide not your face from me.” The invitation to seek God’s face is God’s own. We pray because he invited us. Even if his parents forsake him, which is a deep fear, “the LORD will take me in.” God is a better father than any earthly one. He asks to be taught God’s way and led on a level path, because of his enemies, who breathe violence.

The psalm ends with a statement of faith and an exhortation. “I believe that I shall look upon the goodness of the LORD in the land of the living!” The believer expects to see the goodness of God now, not only in the age to come. And then David turns to us: “Wait for the LORD; be strong, and let your heart take courage; wait for the LORD!” Waiting is the posture of trust. In Christ, our greatest desire is met. He is the true temple, where God dwells with us. He is the light of the world. The beauty of the LORD is seen “in the face of Jesus Christ” (2 Corinthians 4:6).

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 84:1-4 also speaks of longing for God’s dwelling. Psalm 63:1-3 and 42:1-2 speak of thirst for God. John 1:14 and 8:12 present Christ as the dwelling and the light. 2 Corinthians 4:6 speaks of seeing God’s glory in Christ’s face. Isaiah 49:15 speaks of God’s care exceeding a

mother's. Isaiah 40:31 promises renewal to those who wait. Romans 8:31-39 assures us that nothing can separate us from God's love. Hebrews 10:19-22 invites us into God's presence. Revelation 21:22-23 pictures God as the temple and Lamb as the light.

STEP 6

Application

Ask the question: if I could ask for one thing from God, what would it be? Let it be to know him.

Take five minutes to gaze on the beauty of the LORD: read a passage about Christ and meditate on his character.

Wait for the LORD today in a specific matter, and ask him to strengthen your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what you fear, and say, "The LORD is my light and salvation."

Ask him for the one thing: to dwell with him and see his beauty.

Wait for him and take courage.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 807 · WEEK 116

Psalm 138

I give you thanks with my whole heart

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 138. David gives thanks with his whole heart. Notice that his praise is directed to the LORD before other gods, and that it is based on God's steadfast love, his faithfulness, and his answer to prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 138 begins a final group of psalms by David (138 to 145). It is a thanksgiving psalm, offered in response to an answered prayer. David praises God "before the gods," that is, in the presence of the pagan powers and idols, and expects that all the kings of the earth will join. It echoes the Prison Epistles' theme that Christ is exalted above all powers.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I give you thanks, O LORD, with my whole heart; before the gods I sing your praise" (v. 1).
2. "For you have exalted above all things your name and your word" (v. 2).
3. "On the day I called, you answered me; my strength of soul you increased" (v. 3).
4. "All the kings of the earth shall give you thanks, O LORD" (v. 4).
5. "For though the LORD is high, he regards the lowly" (v. 6).
6. "Though I walk in the midst of trouble, you preserve my life" (v. 7).
7. "The LORD will fulfill his purpose for me; your steadfast love, O LORD, endures forever" (v. 8).
8. "Do not forsake the work of your hands" (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with wholehearted praise. David refuses to give thanks halfway. He sings "before the gods," which probably refers to the gods of the nations or the heavenly powers. Even in the presence of rivals, he praises the LORD. He bows toward the holy temple and gives thanks to God's name "for your steadfast love and your faithfulness, for you have exalted above all things your name and your word." God's name is his revealed character, and his word is his promise. Both are supremely reliable.

Verse 3 is a testimony: "On the day I called, you answered me; my strength of soul you increased." The answer was not necessarily the removal of trouble but strength within it. The effect of God's answer extends outward: "All the kings of the earth shall give you thanks, O LORD, for they have heard the words of your mouth, and they shall sing of the ways of the LORD, for great is the glory of the LORD." David's experience of God's faithfulness is a testimony to the nations. This is a missionary note. One day, kings will sing the praises of the LORD.

Verse 6 holds a great truth: "For though the LORD is high, he regards the lowly, but the haughty he knows from afar." God is exalted, and yet he looks on the humble. The proud cannot approach him. This is the theme of the Christ hymn in Philippians 2. The one who humbled himself is now exalted, and God looks on those who humble themselves.

David then expresses trust in future danger: "Though I walk in the midst of trouble, you preserve my life; you stretch out your hand against the wrath of my enemies, and your right hand delivers me." The key promise is verse 8: "The LORD will fulfill his purpose for me." This echoes Philippians 1:6: he who began a good work will bring it to completion. God's purposes for us cannot be thwarted. Based on God's steadfast love that endures forever, David prays, "Do not forsake the work of your hands." It is a prayer of confidence, not doubt: because God has made us and begun a work in us, we ask him to finish it.

STEP 5

Connection

Philippians 1:6 and Psalm 57:2 speak of God fulfilling his purpose. Psalm 100 and 136 emphasize steadfast love. Psalm 72:11 and 102:15 speak of kings worshiping. Isaiah 57:15 says God dwells with the contrite and lowly. James 4:6 and 1 Peter 5:5 say God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble. Luke 1:48-52 is Mary's song of the lowly lifted. Jeremiah 29:11 speaks of God's plans. Revelation 21:24-26 pictures kings bringing glory into the city. Ephesians 2:10 speaks of us as God's workmanship.

STEP 6

Application

Give thanks to God today with your whole heart, with no reservations.

Recall a day you called and he answered. Tell it to someone.

Pray verse 8 over a project or relationship: LORD, fulfill your purpose here.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God thanks with your whole heart, naming something.

Thank him that he exalted his word above his name.

Ask him to complete what he has begun in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 808 · WEEK 116

Psalm 139:13-24

You formed my inward parts

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 139:13-24. You may have read the first half before. Read this section on God's formation of us in the womb and the prayer to be searched and led. Notice how awe and honest self-examination fit together.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 139 is one of the most intimate psalms, celebrating God's knowledge, presence, and creative care. The first twelve verses describe how God knows us completely and is present everywhere. Verses 13 to 18 describe how God made us. Verses 19 to 22 are an outburst against the wicked. Verses 23 and 24 are a closing prayer for God to search the speaker's own heart. It connects with the Prison Epistles' emphasis that we are God's workmanship, known and led by him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother's womb" (v. 13).
2. "I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made" (v. 14).
3. "My frame was not hidden from you, when I was being made in secret" (v. 15).
4. "In your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them" (v. 16).
5. "How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them!" (v. 17).
6. "If I would count them, they are more than the sand" (v. 18).
7. "Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts!" (v. 23).

8 “And lead me in the way everlasting!” (v. 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

David marvels at his own creation. “For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother’s womb.” God is a weaver and an artist. “I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Wonderful are your works; my soul knows it very well.” The human being is a marvel of design, and knowing this produces praise. This psalm is often cited for the dignity of life before birth. The Bible regards the unborn as persons known and formed by God. Every human life is intentionally made.

“My frame was not hidden from you, when I was being made in secret, intricately woven in the depths of the earth.” The “depths of the earth” is a poetic image for the womb, an echo of Adam’s formation from the earth. “Your eyes saw my unformed substance; in your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them.” God’s knowledge extends to our days before we have lived them. This is not a statement of fatalism but of providence. Every day belongs to God.

The reaction: “How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them! If I would count them, they are more than the sand. I awake, and I am still with you.” Dazed by God’s greatness, David finds himself still in God’s presence. Verses 19 to 22 give a strong expression of hatred of God’s enemies: “Do you not hate those who hate you, O LORD?” This sounds jarring, but David’s motive is zeal for God, not private spite. Christians read this in light of Jesus’ command to love our enemies. We hate sin and pray for sinners.

Then the psalm turns from the enemies to himself. “Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting!” After praising God’s knowledge of him, David invites that knowledge to examine him. He does not fear being exposed because he trusts the one who exposes. He wants to be corrected. “The way everlasting” is the way that leads to life, the path of faithfulness. This is a good prayer for each morning.

In Christ, this prayer is safe. Christ knows our sins and yet bore them. He is the way everlasting (John 14:6). The one who searches us is the one who loves us.

STEP 5

Connection

Jeremiah 1:5 says God knew the prophet before forming him in the womb. Job 10:8-12 and Psalm 119:73 also speak of God’s making. Ecclesiastes 11:5 compares the mystery of the womb to God’s works. Luke 1:39-45 mentions John leaping in the womb. Psalm 51:6 and

Hebrews 4:12-13 speak of God's searching knowledge. Psalm 19:12-14 prays for cleansing from hidden faults. Romans 8:29 and Ephesians 1:4 speak of God's knowledge before creation. John 14:6 says Jesus is the way. Matthew 5:43-48 teaches love of enemies.

STEP 6

Application

Thank God today for how you were made. Name something about yourself you've struggled to accept.

Pray verses 23 and 24 at the start of the day, and be ready for the answer.

Treat every person you meet as someone fearfully and wonderfully made, including the unborn and the elderly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that you are fearfully and wonderfully made.
- Ask him to search your heart and lead you in the everlasting way.
- Tell him what anxious thoughts you want him to know.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 809 · WEEK 116

2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18

The man of lawlessness; stand firm; work while you wait

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18. This short letter was written soon after the first. Read it for its three movements: encouragement in persecution (chapter 1), correction about the day of the Lord (chapter 2), and instruction about idleness (chapter 3).

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

A few months after the first letter, Paul learned that the Thessalonians were still suffering and had become confused about the day of the Lord. Someone had claimed, perhaps in a letter allegedly from Paul, that the day of the Lord had already come. Some stopped working, expecting Christ at any moment. Paul writes to comfort the persecuted, correct the misunderstanding, and tell the idle to work.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “To grant relief to you who are afflicted as well as to us, when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with his mighty angels” (1:7).
2. “Let no one deceive you in any way. For that day will not come, unless the rebellion comes first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed” (2:3).
3. “And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will kill with the breath of his mouth” (2:8).
4. “Because God chose you as the firstfruits to be saved, through sanctification by the Spirit and belief in the truth” (2:13).
5. “So then, brothers, stand firm and hold to the traditions that you were taught by us” (2:15).

6. “But the Lord is faithful. He will establish you and guard you against the evil one” (3:3).
7. “If anyone is not willing to work, let him not eat” (3:10).
8. “As for you, brothers, do not grow weary in doing good” (3:13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In chapter 1, Paul thanks God for their growing faith and love and boasts of their steadfastness in persecution. Their suffering is “evidence of the righteous judgment of God, that you may be considered worthy of the kingdom of God.” God will repay with affliction those who afflict them and grant relief to the afflicted “when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with his mighty angels in flaming fire.” Justice will be done. Paul prays that God would make them worthy of his calling, that the name of Jesus may be glorified in them.

Chapter 2 is among the most debated passages in the New Testament. Paul urges them not to be shaken by claims that the day of the Lord has come. “Let no one deceive you in any way. For that day will not come, unless the rebellion comes first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the son of destruction, who opposes and exalts himself against every so-called god or object of worship, so that he takes his seat in the temple of God, proclaiming himself to be God.” Something restrains him, and when the restrainer is removed, the lawless one will be revealed. The Lord Jesus will kill him “with the breath of his mouth and bring to nothing by the appearance of his coming.” His coming will be by the activity of Satan with false signs and wonders, deceiving those who are perishing because they refused to love the truth. Interpreters differ on who the man of lawlessness is: a future individual Antichrist, an institution, a series of persecuting powers (such as Rome or later empires), or a spirit of rebellion embodied in many figures. The restrainer is also variously identified as the Roman Empire, government, the Holy Spirit, or the preaching of the gospel. The key point is clear: Christ will triumph, and believers should not be frightened.

Paul then returns to thanksgiving: “God chose you as the firstfruits to be saved, through sanctification by the Spirit and belief in the truth.” He urges them to stand firm and hold to the traditions they were taught. A prayer: “May our Lord Jesus Christ himself and God our Father, who loved us and gave us eternal comfort and good hope through grace, comfort your hearts and establish them in every good work and word.”

Chapter 3 asks for prayer that the word of the Lord may speed ahead and be honored, and that they may be delivered from wicked and evil people. “But the Lord is faithful. He will establish you and guard you against the evil one.” Then the discipline of idleness. Some were living in idleness, mere busybodies. Paul reminds them of his own example: they worked night and day so as not to burden anyone. “If anyone is not willing to work, let him not eat.” This does not apply to those unable to work, but to those unwilling. He commands them to

work quietly and earn their own living. “As for you, brothers, do not grow weary in doing good.” The letter ends with a benediction of peace and grace, and Paul’s signature as a mark of authenticity.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:25, 9:27, 11:36-37 stand behind the man of lawlessness. Matthew 24:15-28 and 1 John 2:18-22 speak of antichrists. Revelation 13 and 19:19-21 describe the beast and Christ’s victory. Isaiah 11:4 speaks of slaying the wicked with the breath of his lips. 1 Thessalonians 4:11 and 5:14 also address idleness. Ephesians 4:28 and Proverbs 6:6-11 speak of work. Galatians 6:9 repeats the encouragement not to grow weary. John 17:15 prays that God would keep us from the evil one.

STEP 6

Application

If you are suffering for your faith or for doing right, take comfort in 1:5-7. God sees.

Ask if you are tempted to idleness or to being a busybody. What is one productive thing you can do today?

Memorize 3:3 as a promise: the Lord is faithful; he will establish and guard you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he will be revealed from heaven and bring justice.
- Ask him to help you stand firm and not be shaken.
- Ask him to give you strength to keep working while you wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

“Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.”

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 810 · WEEK 116

1 Timothy 1:1-3:16

Sound doctrine; prayer; overseers and deacons

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 49 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Timothy 1:1-3:16. Paul writes to his younger coworker Timothy, who is leading the church in Ephesus. Notice the concern for sound doctrine, the priority of prayer, and the qualifications for overseers and deacons. Read slowly through 3:1-13 and 3:14-16.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus are called the Pastoral Epistles because they were written to pastors, Timothy and Titus, for the care of churches. Paul probably wrote 1 Timothy around AD 62 to 64, after his first Roman imprisonment, to Timothy in Ephesus. False teachers were spreading myths and speculations. Paul instructs Timothy on doctrine, worship, leadership, and conduct in "the household of God, which is the church of the living God."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The aim of our charge is love that issues from a pure heart and a good conscience and a sincere faith" (1:5).
2. "The saying is trustworthy and deserving of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost" (1:15).
3. "Who desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth" (2:4).
4. "For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (2:5).
5. "The saying is trustworthy: If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task" (3:1).

6. “Therefore an overseer must be above reproach” (3:2).
7. “The household of God, which is the church of the living God, a pillar and buttress of the truth” (3:15).
8. “Great indeed, we confess, is the mystery of godliness” (3:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul tells Timothy to charge certain persons not to teach different doctrine, nor to devote themselves to myths and endless genealogies, which promote speculations rather than the stewardship from God that is by faith. “The aim of our charge is love that issues from a pure heart and a good conscience and a sincere faith.” Some have wandered away into vain discussion, desiring to be teachers of the law without understanding. The law is good if one uses it lawfully, as pointing out sin. Then Paul gives his testimony: formerly a blasphemer, persecutor, and insolent opponent, he received mercy because he had acted ignorantly in unbelief. “The saying is trustworthy and deserving of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost.” “Foremost” (or chief) is present tense: Paul still sees himself as the chief of sinners. And he received mercy so that Christ might display his perfect patience as an example. A doxology follows: “To the King of the ages, immortal, invisible, the only God, be honor and glory forever and ever.”

In chapter 2, Paul gives priority to prayer: “First of all, then, I urge that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made for all people, for kings and all who are in high positions, that we may lead a peaceful and quiet life, godly and dignified in every way.” This is pleasing to God our Savior, “who desires all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all.” The gospel is for all kinds of people, and there is only one way. The rest of chapter 2 includes instructions for men and women in worship, including verses 11 to 15 on women teaching, which have been interpreted in different ways. Some hold that Paul restricts the office of elder/teacher to men; others hold that the instruction was shaped by the Ephesian situation, with false teaching among some women; many hold that the passage should be read with attention to the creation reference in verses 13 and 14. Christians who honor Scripture land in different places, so a charitable spirit is called for.

Chapter 3 gives the qualifications for overseers (also called elders or pastors) and deacons. “If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task.” The list is mostly about character: above reproach, the husband of one wife, sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to teach, not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, not a lover of money, managing his household well, not a recent convert, well

thought of by outsiders. Only “able to teach” is a skill. Deacons likewise must be dignified, hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience, be tested, and be faithful. We examine this more on Day 811.

The section ends with the purpose: “I am writing these things to you so that, if I delay, you may know how one ought to behave in the household of God, which is the church of the living God, a pillar and buttress of the truth.” And a hymn: “Great indeed, we confess, is the mystery of godliness: He was manifested in the flesh, vindicated by the Spirit, seen by angels, proclaimed among the nations, believed on in the world, taken up in glory.” The center of church life is Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 20:17-38 records Paul’s farewell to the Ephesian elders. Romans 3:19-20 and 7:12 speak of the use of the law. Acts 9:1-19 tells of Paul’s conversion. Ephesians 2:19-22 describes the household of God. Titus 1:5-9 gives parallel qualifications. Acts 6:1-6 describes the first servants. Philippians 1:1 mentions overseers and deacons. 1 Peter 5:1-4 is Peter’s charge to elders. Hebrews 8:6 and 9:15 speak of the mediator. Philippians 2:5-11 is another early hymn.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for the leaders of the world and of your community by name, as verse 2:1-2 commands.

Pray for the pastors and elders of your church as you read 3:1-7. Which quality do you see in them?

Memorize 1:15 and say it to yourself when you are tempted to think you are too far gone or too good to need grace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for coming to save sinners and for his mercy to you.
- Ask him to help you fight the good fight with a good conscience.
- Pray for those in authority and the people around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

“Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.”

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 811 · WEEK 116

1 Timothy 3:1-13; Titus 1:5-9; Acts 6:1-6

Church Government and Officers

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Timothy 3:1-13, Titus 1:5-9, and Acts 6:1-6. Today is a doctrinal pause on church government and officers. Notice the qualifications for elders and deacons and how the first servants were appointed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

How should a church be organized and led? The New Testament does not give a detailed blueprint, but it does describe the roles of elders (also called overseers or pastors) and deacons, and it describes how the early churches appointed them. Christians have drawn different conclusions about the best form of church government, but there is wide agreement about the character and function of the leaders.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “If anyone aspires to the office of overseer, he desires a noble task” (1 Timothy 3:1).
2. “Able to teach” (1 Timothy 3:2).
3. “Deacons likewise must be dignified, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for dishonest gain” (1 Timothy 3:8).
4. “For those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus” (1 Timothy 3:13).
5. “This is why I left you in Crete, so that you might put what remained into order, and appoint elders in every town as I directed you” (Titus 1:5).

6. “He must hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it” (Titus 1:9).

7. “Therefore, brothers, pick out from among you seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom, whom we will appoint to this duty” (Acts 6:3).

8. “But we will devote ourselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word” (Acts 6:4).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The New Testament speaks of two ongoing offices in the local church: elders (presbyteroi), also called overseers (episkopoi) and shepherds or pastors (poimenes), and deacons (diakonoi). Elders lead, teach, and shepherd the flock. Deacons serve, particularly in practical and material needs. The apostles were a unique foundational office, which has not continued.

Elders and overseers appear to be the same office, since Paul uses the terms interchangeably in Titus 1:5-7 and Acts 20:17, 28. Their qualifications emphasize character: above reproach, faithful to their spouse, self-controlled, hospitable, gentle, not greedy, managing their household well. Their tasks are to teach, shepherd, guard the flock from false teaching, and lead. The only ability required is to teach. In Acts 20:28, Paul tells the Ephesian elders to “care for the church of God, which he obtained with his own blood.”

Deacons came from the appointment of the seven in Acts 6, so that the apostles could devote themselves to prayer and the ministry of the word, while others cared for widows’ food. The seven were “men of good repute, full of the Spirit and of wisdom.” Deacons serve the church’s practical needs and free the elders to lead and teach. Romans 16:1 calls Phoebe a deacon (or servant) of the church at Cenchreae. Christians differ on whether women may serve as deacons: some read 1 Timothy 3:11 as referring to women deacons, others to the wives of deacons.

Churches organize themselves in different ways. The episcopal model (Roman Catholic, Orthodox, Anglican, Methodist) has bishops who oversee multiple congregations. The presbyterian model has elders who govern the church and regional bodies of elders (presbyteries and assemblies). The congregational model (Baptist and many independent churches) holds that the local congregation is the final earthly authority, led by elders and deacons. Disagreements remain over the role of the congregation, the relationship between local churches, and who may hold office, including whether women may be elders. These are important matters, and we should study them in humility.

Agreed principles: leaders are servants, not lords (1 Peter 5:3; Mark 10:42-45). Their authority comes from Scripture. They are accountable to Christ, the chief shepherd, and to the church. The congregation should respect and follow godly leaders (Hebrews 13:17), while testing everything by the word.

STEP 4

Interpretation

1 Timothy 3:1 says that aspiring to the office of overseer is a noble desire. But the emphasis is on character. “Above reproach” means no charge can be brought against his life. “The husband of one wife” is generally understood as faithful to his wife, though Christians differ on whether it excludes divorced and remarried men, singles, or women. “Sober-minded, self-controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to teach, not a drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, not a lover of money. He must manage his own household well, with all dignity keeping his children submissive, for if someone does not know how to manage his own household, how will he care for God’s church? He must not be a recent convert, or he may become puffed up with conceit. Moreover, he must be well thought of by outsiders.” The home is the proving ground.

Deacons likewise must be dignified. They must hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. They are to be tested first, and then let them serve if they prove themselves blameless. “For those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.”

In Titus 1, Paul left Titus in Crete to appoint elders in every town. The qualifications are similar. The elder, as God’s steward, must be above reproach, not arrogant or quick-tempered, a lover of good, self-controlled, upright, holy. “He must hold firm to the trustworthy word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it.” The elder both builds up and guards.

Acts 6 shows how the first church solved a problem. The Hellenist widows were being neglected in the daily distribution. The Twelve said, “It is not right that we should give up preaching the word of God to serve tables.” They asked the church to pick out seven men of good repute, full of the Spirit and wisdom. The church chose, the apostles prayed and laid hands on them, “and the word of God continued to increase.” Notice the shape: leaders delegate; the congregation participates; the priority is the word and prayer; the result is growth.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 14:23 and 20:17-38 describe the appointment of elders. 1 Peter 5:1-5 gives Peter's charge to elders. Hebrews 13:7, 17 speak of respecting leaders. Philippians 1:1 greets overseers and deacons. Romans 16:1-2 mentions Phoebe. Ephesians 4:11-12 speaks of shepherds and teachers equipping the saints. 3 John 9-10 warns of a domineering leader. Mark 10:42-45 contrasts Jesus' model of leadership with the world's. 1 Corinthians 12:28 lists gifts of administration and helping. Matthew 20:25-28 echoes the servant principle.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for your elders and deacons by name. Thank at least one for something specific.

If God is leading you to aspire to serve as a leader, ask a pastor to help you test it by these qualifications.

Find a practical need in your church and meet it, as the seven did.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus, the Chief Shepherd, for the leaders he has given his church.

Pray for your own church leaders by name.

Ask him to help you follow and support them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 116

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

DAY 812 · WEEK 116

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Thessalonians 5:16-18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Rejoice always, pray without ceasing, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you."

1 THESSALONIANS 5:16-18

REST

Meditation

These three short commands are among the simplest and most challenging in the Bible.

"Rejoice always." Joy that does not depend on circumstances is possible because its source is the Lord. Paul is not asking us to feel happy about suffering but to rejoice in God's presence, promises, and salvation. Even tears and joy can coexist.

"Pray without ceasing." This does not mean we stay on our knees all day, but that we live in constant awareness of God, turning to him in short prayers throughout the day and setting aside times for deeper prayer. It is a posture of dependence.

"Give thanks in all circumstances." Not for all circumstances, but in them. We can thank God in the midst of loss because he is with us and working. Gratitude changes our outlook.

“For this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.” Many people wonder about God’s will. Here is a clear answer: joy, prayer, and thanksgiving. And it is “in Christ Jesus”: the power to do it comes from him.

When your day becomes anxious, say this verse and take one of these three steps right then.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the end of 1 Thessalonians, with its call to holy living, the day of the Lord, and short commands to rejoice, pray, and give thanks. Three psalms taught confidence and wonder: Psalm 27, one thing I ask, to dwell in the house of the LORD and gaze upon his beauty; Psalm 138, I give you thanks with my whole heart, and the LORD will fulfill his purpose for me; and Psalm 139, I am fearfully and wonderfully made, search me and lead me in the way everlasting. Second Thessalonians comforted the persecuted, warned against being shaken by claims about the day of the Lord, and called the idle to work. First Timothy began the Pastoral Epistles with sound doctrine, prayer for all people, the one mediator, and the qualifications of overseers and deacons. A doctrinal pause considered church government and officers: elders who shepherd and teach, deacons who serve, and a congregation that follows godly leaders.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Psalm 27 says the one thing David asked for was to dwell in the house of the LORD and gaze on his beauty. What would you say is the one thing you most seek? How could you ask God to make knowing him your deepest desire?

Second Thessalonians says, “The Lord is faithful. He will establish you and guard you against the evil one.” What threat or fear in your life do you need to entrust to God’s faithfulness?

Paul gives Timothy a list of character qualities for church leaders, mostly about integrity and home life. Which of these do you most want to grow in, whether or not you’re a leader? What is one step?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the call to rejoice, pray, and give thanks.

Tell him what you have to give thanks for in your circumstances.

Rest in him.

DAY 813 · WEEK 117

1 Timothy 4:1-6:21

Godliness; widows and elders; the good fight

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 69 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Timothy 4:1-6:21. Paul gives Timothy instruction on guarding against false teaching, on his own example and ministry, on caring for various groups in the church, and on the dangers of money. Notice how often Paul turns from doctrine to daily conduct.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul continues his letter to Timothy in Ephesus. False teachers were forbidding marriage and certain foods, and others were using religion for profit. Timothy was young and perhaps timid. Paul encourages him to be an example, to devote himself to public reading of Scripture, and to fight the good fight of faith. The letter also gives guidance for widows, elders, slaves and masters, and the rich.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving” (4:4).
2. “For while bodily training is of some value, godliness is of value in every way” (4:8).
3. “Let no one despise you for your youth, but set the believers an example in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity” (4:12).
4. “Devote yourself to the public reading of Scripture, to exhortation, to teaching” (4:13).
5. “Keep a close watch on yourself and on the teaching. Persist in this, for by so doing you will save both yourself and your hearers” (4:16).
6. “But godliness with contentment is great gain” (6:6).

7. “For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils” (6:10).
8. “Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called” (6:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 4 opens with a warning that in later times some will depart from the faith, devoting themselves to deceitful spirits and teachings of demons. They forbid marriage and require abstinence from foods. Paul answers with creation: “For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, for it is made holy by the word of God and prayer.” Marriage and food are gifts. Christians are free to enjoy them with gratitude, though not to worship them.

Timothy is to be a good servant of Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith. He is to have nothing to do with irreverent myths and to train himself for godliness. “For while bodily training is of some value, godliness is of value in every way, as it holds promise for the present life and also for the life to come.” Exercise is good, but spiritual discipline matters more and lasts. “Let no one despise you for your youth, but set the believers an example in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity.” Authority comes from example. Until Paul arrives, Timothy is to give attention to Scripture reading, exhortation, and teaching, and not to neglect the gift given to him when the elders laid their hands on him. “Keep a close watch on yourself and on the teaching.” A pastor must watch both his life and his doctrine.

Chapter 5 gives practical guidance. Treat older men as fathers, younger men as brothers, older women as mothers, younger women as sisters, in all purity. Care for widows who are truly in need, and let families care for their own: “If anyone does not provide for his relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever.” Elders who rule well are worthy of double honor, especially those who labor in preaching and teaching, and the worker deserves his wages. Accusations against an elder require two or three witnesses, and those who persist in sin are to be rebuked publicly. Timothy is to keep these rules without prejudice or partiality, to be careful about laying on hands hastily, and to keep himself pure. Paul adds a small word about his health: “No longer drink only water, but use a little wine for the sake of your stomach and your frequent ailments.”

Chapter 6 speaks to slaves and masters, and to false teachers who suppose that godliness is a means of gain. “But godliness with contentment is great gain, for we brought nothing into the world, and we cannot take anything out of the world.” Those who desire to be rich fall into temptation. “For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils. It is through this craving that some have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many pangs.”

Note that it is the love of money, not money itself. Timothy is to flee these things and pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, steadfastness, gentleness. “Fight the good fight of the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which you were called.” The rich are to be generous and rich in good works, storing up treasure as a good foundation for the future. The letter ends with a plea: “O Timothy, guard the deposit entrusted to you.”

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:31 and Mark 7:19 affirm the goodness of creation and food. Hebrews 13:4 honors marriage. Acts 16:1-3 introduces Timothy. 2 Timothy 1:6 mentions his gift. Deuteronomy 25:4 and Luke 10:7 are behind the wage principle. Philippians 4:11-13 speaks of contentment. Matthew 6:19-24 teaches that we cannot serve God and money. Hebrews 13:5 says to be content with what you have. Ecclesiastes 5:10 warns about loving money. Jude 3 speaks of contending for the faith.

STEP 6

Application

Receive your next meal and a gift in your life with thanksgiving, and say the prayer aloud.

Ask which area of your life (speech, conduct, love, faith, purity) most needs to be an example, and take one step.

Examine your relationship with money. Ask: what do I love? Plan one generous gift this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Receive God’s gifts with thanksgiving, and name some.
- Ask him to train you for godliness.
- Ask him to help you fight the good fight of faith.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 814 · WEEK 117

2 Timothy 1:1-2:26

Guard the deposit; rightly handling the word

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Timothy 1:1-2:26. This is Paul's last letter, written from prison with death near. Notice the tenderness toward Timothy, the call to guard the gospel, and the pictures of the faithful servant: soldier, athlete, farmer, worker.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Second Timothy was written around AD 66 to 67, during Paul's second imprisonment in Rome, probably shortly before his execution. Unlike his first imprisonment, this one is harsh, and Paul is alone except for Luke. He writes to Timothy, his beloved child in the faith, to strengthen him to carry on, to guard the gospel, and to be willing to suffer. It is a farewell letter and a passing of the torch.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control" (1:7).
2. "Who saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace" (1:9).
3. "For I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard until that day what has been entrusted to me" (1:12).
4. "By the Holy Spirit who dwells within us, guard the good deposit entrusted to you" (1:14).
5. "And what you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men, who will be able to teach others also" (2:2).
6. "Share in suffering as a good soldier of Christ Jesus" (2:3).

7. “Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth” (2:15).

8. “The Lord’s servant must not be quarrelsome but kind to everyone, able to teach, patiently enduring evil” (2:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul begins with thanks and longing. He remembers Timothy’s tears, recalls the sincere faith that lived in his grandmother Lois and mother Eunice, and reminds him to fan into flame the gift of God that is in him. “For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control.” Timothy seems to have been timid. Fear is not from God, and the Spirit gives courage, love, and discipline. “Therefore do not be ashamed of the testimony about our Lord, nor of me his prisoner, but share in suffering for the gospel by the power of God.”

Then a summary of the gospel: God “saved us and called us to a holy calling, not because of our works but because of his own purpose and grace, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before the ages began, and which now has been manifested through the appearing of our Savior Christ Jesus, who abolished death and brought life and immortality to light through the gospel.” Paul is not ashamed, even in a dungeon: “For I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard until that day what has been entrusted to me.” Faith is knowing a person. Paul urges Timothy to follow the pattern of sound words and to guard the good deposit by the Holy Spirit. Some, like Phygelus and Hermogenes, have turned away. Onesiphorus, however, was not ashamed of Paul’s chains and refreshed him often, and Paul prays mercy on his household.

Chapter 2 builds on the picture of ministry as hard work. Timothy is to be strengthened by the grace in Christ Jesus and to pass on the gospel: “What you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men, who will be able to teach others also.” Four generations appear here: Paul, Timothy, faithful men, and others. Discipleship is multiplication. Then three images: the soldier, who avoids civilian entanglements to please his commander; the athlete, who competes by the rules; the farmer, who works hard before sharing the crops. Each requires single-mindedness, discipline, and patience. “Remember Jesus Christ, risen from the dead, the offspring of David, as preached in my gospel, for which I am suffering, bound with chains. But the word of God is not bound!”

Paul quotes a trustworthy saying: “If we have died with him, we will also live with him; if we endure, we will also reign with him; if we deny him, he also will deny us; if we are faithless, he remains faithful, for he cannot deny himself.” Timothy is to avoid quarrels about words and irreverent babble. “Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth.” Some have swerved

from the truth, like Hymenaeus and Philetus, who say the resurrection has already happened. But “God’s firm foundation stands, bearing this seal: The Lord knows those who are his.” The household of God contains vessels for honor and for dishonor; Timothy is to cleanse himself, flee youthful passions, and pursue righteousness, faith, love, and peace. The Lord’s servant must be kind, patient, and gentle in correcting opponents, in the hope that God may grant them repentance.

STEP 5

Connection

Acts 16:1-3 introduces Timothy and his mother. 1 Timothy 1:18 and 4:14 refer to his gift. Romans 1:16 says Paul is not ashamed of the gospel. Titus 3:5-7 echoes salvation by mercy and not works. Ephesians 1:4 speaks of grace given before the ages. 1 Corinthians 9:24-27 uses the athlete image. Philippians 2:25 and Philemon 2 use soldier language. Numbers 16:5 is quoted in 2:19. Matthew 28:19-20 gives the mission of making disciples. Romans 6:8 and 8:17 parallel the faithful saying.

STEP 6

Application

Name a fear that holds you back and ask God for his spirit of power, love, and self-control.

Think of the people who passed the faith to you. Write to one to thank them. Then think of who you might pass it to.

Which picture fits you today: soldier, athlete, farmer, or worker? Take one step in that direction.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for giving you a spirit of power, love, and self-control.
- Ask him to help you guard the good deposit.
- Ask him to help you handle his word rightly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 815 · WEEK 117

2 Timothy 3:1-4:22

Difficult times; preach the word; finish the race

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Timothy 3:1-4:22. These are Paul's last recorded words. Notice the warning about hard times, the great statement about Scripture, the solemn charge to preach, and Paul's own testimony as he faces death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Paul writes his final instructions to Timothy. He knows his time is short. The church will face difficult days, and false teachers will multiply. His solution is not new methods but the faithful preaching of the word. These verses contain the most important statement in the Bible about the nature of Scripture, and they also give a deeply moving portrait of a servant at the end of his race.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But understand this, that in the last days there will come times of difficulty" (3:1).
2. "Indeed, all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted" (3:12).
3. "And how from childhood you have been acquainted with the sacred writings, which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus" (3:15).
4. "All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness" (3:16).
5. "Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching" (4:2).
6. "For the time is coming when people will not endure sound teaching, but having itching ears they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own passions" (4:3).

7. “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith” (4:7).
8. “But the Lord stood by me and strengthened me, so that through me the message might be fully proclaimed” (4:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul says that “in the last days there will come times of difficulty.” The last days began with Christ’s first coming, so this is a description of the whole era. People will be lovers of self, lovers of money, proud, abusive, disobedient, ungrateful, unholy, heartless, unforgiving, slanderous, without self-control, brutal, haters of good, treacherous, reckless, swollen with conceit, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, “having the appearance of godliness, but denying its power.” Timothy is to avoid such people. Paul contrasts them with Timothy: “You, however, have followed my teaching, my conduct, my aim in life, my faith, my patience, my love, my steadfastness, my persecutions and sufferings.” Then a sober truth: “Indeed, all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted, while evil people and impostors will go on from bad to worse, deceiving and being deceived.”

Timothy must continue in what he has learned. He knows from whom he learned it and has known “the sacred writings” from childhood, “which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus.” Then the great statement: “All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.” The word “breathed out” (theopneustos) means that Scripture originates in God. It is his word, just as a human’s breath carries his words. It is profitable in four ways: it teaches what is true, reproves what is wrong, corrects the path, and trains in righteousness. And its goal is that we be complete, equipped for every good work. Scripture is sufficient for the life of faith.

Chapter 4 begins with a solemn charge, “in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus, who is to judge the living and the dead.” The command is simple: “Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching.” The reason is that people will turn away. “They will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own passions, and will turn away from listening to the truth and wander off into myths.” Timothy is to be sober-minded, endure suffering, do the work of an evangelist, and fulfill his ministry.

Then Paul looks at his own end: “For I am already being poured out as a drink offering, and the time of my departure has come. I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. Henceforth there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will award to me on that day, and not only to me but also to all who have loved his appearing.” The letter closes with personal notes: Demas has deserted him,

only Luke is with him, and he asks for Mark, his cloak, and his books and parchments. At his first defense, no one came to stand by him, "but the Lord stood by me and strengthened me." "The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and bring me safely into his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory forever and ever. Amen."

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 24:9-13 and 2 Peter 3:3 also warn of hard times. John 15:20 promises persecution. 2 Peter 1:20-21 explains the origin of Scripture. Psalm 19:7-11 and 119:105 praise Scripture's value. Luke 24:44-47 shows Scripture pointing to Christ. Acts 20:24 is Paul's earlier statement about finishing his course. Philippians 2:17 and 1:21-23 also use the drink offering image. 1 Peter 5:4 promises a crown to faithful shepherds. Acts 23:11 and 27:23-24 recall times Christ stood by Paul. Hebrews 4:12 speaks of the living word.

STEP 6

Application

Choose a time and place for reading the Bible every day, and commit to it. Ask God to use Scripture to teach, reprove, correct, and train you.

Let 3:16-17 stay with you.

Ask whether you are finishing well. What is one thing you need to do to keep the faith?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that all Scripture is breathed out by him.
- Ask him to use it to teach, reprove, correct, and train you.
- Ask him to help you finish well.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 816 · WEEK 117

Titus 1:1-3:15

Elders; sound doctrine; good works

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 46 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Titus 1:1-3:15. This short letter to Titus in Crete shows how sound doctrine and good works belong together. Notice the repeated phrases “sound doctrine” and “good works,” and the gospel summaries in 2:11-14 and 3:4-7.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Titus was one of Paul’s trusted coworkers, a Gentile convert. Paul left him on the island of Crete to put the churches in order and appoint elders in every town. The Cretans had a reputation for dishonesty and laziness (even one of their own poets said so), and false teachers were upsetting households. Paul writes to give Titus authority and instructions, and in doing so gives some of the clearest summaries of the gospel in the New Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “They profess to know God, but they deny him by their works” (1:16).
2. “But as for you, teach what accords with sound doctrine” (2:1).
3. “For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation for all people” (2:11).
4. “Waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ” (2:13).
5. “Who gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works” (2:14).
6. “He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit” (3:5).

7. “The saying is trustworthy, and I want you to insist on these things, so that those who have believed in God may be careful to devote themselves to good works” (3:8).

8. “But avoid foolish controversies, genealogies, dissensions, and quarrels about the law, for they are unprofitable and worthless” (3:9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul opens with a long greeting that sets the gospel in eternity: he is a servant of God and apostle of Jesus Christ for the sake of the faith of God’s elect and their knowledge of the truth, “in hope of eternal life, which God, who never lies, promised before the ages began.” Then the task: appoint elders (covered on Day 811) and silence the empty talkers who upset whole families. The Cretans, as one of their own prophets said, were “always liars, evil beasts, lazy gluttons.” Titus is to rebuke them sharply that they may be sound in the faith. “To the pure, all things are pure, but to the defiled and unbelieving, nothing is pure; their very minds and consciences are defiled. They profess to know God, but they deny him by their works.”

Chapter 2 gives instruction for each group in the church: older men, older women, younger women, younger men, and slaves. The goal in all cases is to “adorn the doctrine of God our Savior” and keep the word of God from being reviled. Doctrine and life belong together. Then the gospel as the basis for this life: “For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation for all people, training us to renounce ungodliness and worldly passions, and to live self-controlled, upright, and godly lives in the present age, waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ, who gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works.” Grace does not excuse sin but trains us out of it. Christ is called “our great God and Savior,” one of the plain statements of his deity. He gave himself to redeem and to purify.

In chapter 3, Paul tells Titus to remind believers to be submissive to rulers, to be ready for every good work, to speak evil of no one, and to show perfect courtesy toward all people. Why? Because “we ourselves were once foolish, disobedient, led astray, slaves to various passions and pleasures.” Then the second great summary: “But when the goodness and loving kindness of God our Savior appeared, he saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior, so that being justified by his grace we might become heirs according to the hope of eternal life.” Here the Father, Son, and Spirit all work for our salvation. It is entirely mercy; it is new birth; it makes us heirs.

Paul concludes: insist on these things, so that believers will devote themselves to good works. Avoid foolish controversies. Warn a divisive person once, then twice, and then have nothing to do with him. The letter ends with practical greetings and the blessing, “Grace be with you all.”

STEP 5

Connection

Ephesians 2:8-10 also joins salvation by grace with good works. Romans 6:1-4 answers whether grace excuses sin. John 3:3-8 and 1 Peter 1:3 speak of new birth. Romans 5:1-2 and 8:17 speak of justification and heirs. Deuteronomy 7:6 and 1 Peter 2:9 speak of a people for God’s own possession. 2 Peter 1:1 and John 20:28 also call Christ God. Matthew 28:19 names Father, Son, and Spirit. Romans 13:1-7 speaks of rulers. James 2:14-26 joins faith and works. Matthew 5:16 speaks of good works glorifying the Father.

STEP 6

Application

Read 2:11-14 slowly. Underline each work of grace: it appears, saves, trains, redeems, purifies.

Pick one “good work” you can do for someone this week as a fruit of grace, and do it.

Remember the person you were before Christ (3:3) the next time you are tempted to be harsh with someone.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for redeeming you and purifying a people for himself.
- Ask him to make you zealous for good works.
- Ask him to keep you from foolish arguments.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

“All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 817 · WEEK 117

Philemon 1:1-25

Onesimus, grace transforms every relationship

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Philemon, a one-chapter letter. It is Paul's most personal letter, a short appeal on behalf of a runaway slave named Onesimus. Read it slowly, imagining Philemon opening it before the whole church that meets in his house.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Philemon was a wealthy Christian in Colossae, with a church in his house. His slave Onesimus ran away, perhaps after stealing, and somehow met Paul in prison, where he became a Christian. Paul is sending Onesimus back, with this letter, asking Philemon to receive him not as a slave but as a beloved brother. It was sent with the Colossian letter, carried by Tychicus and Onesimus (Colossians 4:7-9).

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I thank my God always when I remember you in my prayers, because I hear of your love and of the faith that you have toward the Lord Jesus and for all the saints" (vv. 4-5).
2. "For this reason, though I am bold enough in Christ to command you to do what is required, yet for love's sake I prefer to appeal to you" (vv. 8-9).
3. "I appeal to you for my child, Onesimus, whom I have begotten in my imprisonment" (v. 10).
4. "Formerly he was useless to you, but now he is indeed useful to you and to me" (v. 11).
5. "No longer as a bondservant but more than a bondservant, as a beloved brother" (v. 16).
6. "So if you consider me your partner, receive him as you would receive me" (v. 17).
7. "If he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, charge that to my account" (v. 18).

8 “Confident of your obedience, I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Paul writes as a prisoner of Christ Jesus, with Timothy, to Philemon, Apphia, Archippus, and the church in the house. He begins with thanks for Philemon’s love and faith, and prays that the sharing of his faith may become effective for the full knowledge of every good thing in Christ. Paul has “derived much joy and comfort from your love, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed through you, my brother.” This builds up goodwill before the request.

Then the appeal. Paul could command, but “for love’s sake I prefer to appeal to you.” The appeal is for Onesimus, whose name means “useful.” Paul puns on it: “Formerly he was useless to you, but now he is indeed useful to you and to me.” Paul calls Onesimus his child and says, “I am sending him back to you, sending my very heart.” He would have liked to keep him, but would do nothing without Philemon’s consent, “in order that your goodness might not be by compulsion but of your own accord.”

Paul offers a perspective on the situation: “For this perhaps is why he was parted from you for a while, that you might have him back forever, no longer as a bondservant but more than a bondservant, as a beloved brother.” Providence may have been at work. Onesimus is a brother both in the flesh and in the Lord. Then Paul puts himself in the middle: “So if you consider me your partner, receive him as you would receive me. If he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, charge that to my account. I, Paul, write this with my own hand: I will repay it.” He adds, gently, that Philemon owes Paul his very self.

This is a picture of the gospel. Onesimus, the guilty one, owes a debt. Paul, the innocent, steps in and says, charge it to me. Receive him as you would receive me. This is imputation: the debt of the guilty is put on the account of another, and the standing of the innocent is given to the guilty. Christ does this for us before the Father. We are welcomed because we come in his name.

The letter does not directly attack slavery as an institution, though it undermines its foundations by declaring a slave a brother and by asking that he be received as Paul himself. Elsewhere Paul lists slave traders among the lawless (1 Timothy 1:10), and the principle that in Christ there is neither slave nor free (Galatians 3:28) worked itself out over time. Paul closes by expressing confidence that Philemon will do even more than he asks, and asks for a guest room, hoping to be released. He sends greetings from Epaphras, Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, and Luke.

STEP 5

Connection

Colossians 4:7-9 mentions Onesimus. Galatians 3:28 and Colossians 3:11 declare that in Christ there is neither slave nor free. 1 Corinthians 7:21-24 speaks to slaves. Ephesians 6:5-9 gives instruction to slaves and masters. 1 Timothy 6:1-2 mentions believing masters. Isaiah 53:4-6 and 2 Corinthians 5:21 speak of Christ taking our debt. Romans 8:1 assures there is no condemnation. Matthew 18:21-35 teaches forgiveness. Luke 15:20-24 pictures the welcome of the returning son.

STEP 6

Application

Is there someone you need to forgive or receive back? Take a step this week, in the spirit of Paul's appeal.

Read the letter again, putting yourself in Onesimus's place, and thank Christ for standing in for you.

Think about whom you may stand beside in an appeal for mercy or justice.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for taking your debt on himself.
- Ask him to show you a relationship that needs the grace you have received.
- Ask him to help you receive others as brothers and sisters.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 117

"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

DAY 818 · WEEK 117

Review and Reflection

Unit 22 review, In Christ, Prison & Pastoral Epistles

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation. For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth."
>
> COLOSSIANS 1:15-16

REST

Meditation

Paul lifts our eyes to Christ. He is "the image of the invisible God." No one has seen God, but we see him in Jesus. He is "the firstborn of all creation," which means he has the rank and inheritance of the firstborn, not that he was created. "For by him all things were created, in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or dominions or rulers or authorities." The powers that the Colossians feared are creatures, made by him and for him.

This verse is the foundation of the whole Prison and Pastoral section. If Christ is this great, we are secure in him, the church is his body, our work is for him, and our hope is his appearing. Say it slowly. Each phrase is a reason to worship.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit took us through the Prison and Pastoral Epistles. Ephesians showed us God's plan from eternity: chosen in Christ, saved by grace through faith, made one new people, and equipped to walk in love, light, and the whole armor of God. Psalms 68 and 110 celebrated the ascended Christ as priest-king. Philippians showed joy in chains, the humility and exaltation of Christ in the great hymn, and the surpassing worth of knowing him. Colossians declared the supremacy of Christ over all things and taught us to live in him, setting our minds on things above and doing everything in the name of the Lord Jesus. We paused to consider election, the church, the person of Christ as fully God and fully man, and ordinary work as a calling. In 1 and 2 Thessalonians, we learned to wait for the Lord's return with hope and with work, and to stand firm in persecution. Psalms 27, 138, and 139 taught us to

seek the LORD's face, give thanks with the whole heart, and be searched and led by the one who made us. In 1 Timothy we learned how the household of God should live, with sound doctrine, prayer, and godly leaders. In 2 Timothy we heard Paul's last words: guard the gospel, rightly handle the word, and trust that all Scripture is breathed out by God. Titus showed how grace trains us for good works, and Philemon showed the gospel at work in one friendship, with Paul standing in for the guilty.

REFLECT

Review Questions

Ephesians 2:8-10 and Titus 3:4-7 both say we are saved by grace, not works, and yet for good works. How do these fit together?

Write in your own words how salvation by grace leads to a life of good works, and give an example from your own life.

Philippians 2:5-11 and Colossians 1:15-20 both describe Christ. What do they teach about who he is and what he has done?

List three truths about Christ from these passages and say how each strengthens your trust or worship.

Paul writes many of these letters from prison. What do Philippians and 2 Timothy show about how a believer can face hardship?

Choose a hardship you or someone you know is facing and apply one truth from these letters.

2 Timothy 3:16-17 says all Scripture is breathed out by God. What difference does this make to how you read the Bible?

Describe one change you will make to your reading habits, based on what Scripture is and what it does.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the letters of Paul and what they have taught you.

Thank him for Christ in whom all things hold together.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 819 · WEEK 117

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 22 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Timothy 3:16-17 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17

REST

Meditation

This is the Bible's own testimony about itself. "All Scripture" means every part, not just our favorite passages. "Breathed out by God" means it comes from him, carrying his authority and truthfulness. It is not merely helpful human wisdom.

Then the four purposes: teaching (what to believe), reproof (where we are wrong), correction (how to get back on the path), and training in righteousness (how to grow). Notice that Scripture does not only inform us; it forms us. It confronts and repairs us.

The goal is "that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work." This verse applies to every believer, not only to pastors. God's word is enough to equip us for what he calls us to do. The next time you open the Bible, pray this verse first, and ask the Spirit to do each of the four things.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the Pastoral Epistles. First Timothy 4 to 6 taught that everything God created is good, that godliness is of value in every way, and that the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils. Second Timothy 1 and 2 gave Paul's farewell charge: a spirit of power, love, and self-control; guard the deposit; entrust the gospel to faithful people; and rightly handle the word of truth. Second Timothy 3 and 4 gave the great statement of Scripture's inspiration and Paul's last testimony: I have fought the good fight, finished the race, kept the faith. Titus joined sound doctrine with good works and gave two summaries of the gospel. Philemon pictured the gospel in a personal appeal, with Paul saying, charge it to my account. On Day 818 we reviewed the whole Prison and Pastoral unit.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Paul says Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, reproof, correction, and training in righteousness. Which of these four do you most need from the Bible right now, and what passage might you read for it?

In Philemon, Paul offers to take on Onesimus's debt. How does this help you understand what Christ has done for you, and how might it shape your relationship with someone who has wronged you?

Paul ends his life saying, "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith." What would you want to be able to say at the end of your life? What is one step toward it this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for his breathed-out word, able to make you wise for salvation.

Ask him to equip you for every good work.

Rest in him.